

Medium Income 2026

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The Beginner's Playbook to Your First \$100 — Updated for the 2026 Partner Program

12 chapters · 100+ countries · zero-to-payout. From a working dev who earns on Medium today, for writers anywhere in the world.

Who This Is For

- **Complete beginners** who have never published a single story on Medium — you will go from zero account to first payout in this guide.
- **Returning writers** who had a Medium account before 2023, posted a few times, then stepped away — the Partner Program rules changed significantly and what you remember may no longer be accurate.
- **Non-US and non-UK writers** in Asia, Africa, Europe, and Latin America who have Googled ‘does Medium pay outside the US’ and gotten six different answers and wonder whether the program even pays out in their country (it does — 100+ countries are supported via Stripe Express).
- **Niche experts** — developers, designers, UX writers, indie coaches, and subject-matter specialists — who want to monetize the knowledge they already have instead of learning an entirely new skill.
- **Side-income seekers** whose immediate goal is straightforward: earn the first \$100 per month from writing, prove the model works, and then decide whether to scale.

If you already earn \$1,000+ per month on Medium and have a well-established publishing routine, this guide probably does not add much for you. It is designed to get someone to the first milestone, not to optimize an existing high-performing account.

What's NOT In This Book

- **Not a get-rich-quick scheme.** The \$17–\$92/month I earn is real money, but it took consistent work over several months. Anyone promising \$5,000 in 30 days from Medium is selling you a fantasy.
 - **Not viral hacks or clap-trade groups.** Those tactics may have worked in 2018. Medium's current algorithm rewards genuine read time, not clap exchanges or follow-for-follow loops. We ignore them entirely.
 - **Not for writers already earning \$1K+/month.** If you are at that level, you need advanced distribution, staff writing, or paid newsletter strategy — not a beginner playbook. This guide ends at the milestone of consistent monthly earnings, not at scaling to a full-time income.
 - **Not US-only.** This is explicitly written for a global audience. The Stripe Express setup chapter covers country-by-country tax notes, and the eligibility chapter addresses every common rejection reason for non-US applicants.
 - **Not an AI-content workaround.** Medium's updated policy requires that AI-assisted stories are disclosed and that the human author adds genuine editorial value. This guide follows that policy. We use AI as a drafting aid, not as a ghostwriter you submit verbatim.
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How To Use This Book In 14 Days

You do not need to read this cover to cover before you start. The chapters are sequenced so you can read and act on each one immediately.

Day	Focus	Reading
1	Understand the 2026 economy and verify your eligibility	Ch 1 — The 2026 Medium Economy
2	Confirm eligibility, understand country rules, review rejection traps	Ch 2 — Eligibility Without Confusion
3	Set up or overhaul your profile for first impressions	Ch 3 — Setting Up Your Profile to Convert
4	Learn the title formula — write 10 practice titles for your niche	Ch 4 — The Number+Hook Title Formula
5	Study the 7-part article skeleton; pick your niche template	Ch 5 — The 7-Part Article Skeleton
6	Day 1 of your first article — open a blank doc, set the skeleton	Ch 6 — Your First Article in 14 Days
7	Day 2 of first article — write the opening and body sections	Ch 6 (continued)
8	Research publications; identify your top-3 target publications	Ch 7 — Publications: Pitch & Get In

Day	Focus	Reading
9	Learn engagement mechanics; add Friend Link footer to your draft	Ch 8 — Engagement Mechanics
10	Final edit, set Friend Link, submit to publication or self-publish	Ch 6 (submission day)
11	Connect Stripe Express; complete tax interview	Ch 9 — Stripe Payout Worldwide
12	Apply to the Medium Partner Program; set up payout threshold	Ch 9 (continued) + apply MPP
13	Plan your 90-day calendar; schedule next 4 article topics	Ch 10 — The 90-Day Calendar
14	Design your first Gumroad funnel from your best story	Ch 11–12 — Repurpose + What Comes Next

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1 — The 2026 Medium Economy

What This Chapter Covers

- Why most “how to earn on Medium” guides you’ll find today teach rules that no longer exist
- How Medium’s two reader tiers — Member and Friend — determine how much you actually earn per minute of read time
- The February 17, 2026 conversion bonus: a new payout mechanic that rewards stories bringing in new paying readers
- What the real earnings numbers look like from a working writer with 1,171 followers — honest range, not highlight-reel figures

Why 2023+ Guides Are Wrong

If you’ve searched for advice on earning money from Medium recently, you’ve probably landed on guides that say something like: “Just publish five stories, get 100 followers, and you’re in the Partner Program.” That was true once. It is not true anymore.

In August 2023, Medium rebuilt the Medium Partner Program (MPP) from the ground up. Two things changed that made most existing guides obsolete overnight:

The 100-follower minimum was removed. You no longer need to reach any follower threshold before applying. A writer with zero followers can apply on day one.

Writers must be paying Medium members to participate. This is the rule that almost every outdated guide misses. To earn money through the MPP, you must hold an active paid Medium membership — either \$5 per month or \$50 per year at the Member tier, or \$15 per month or \$150 per year at the Friend tier. Free accounts cannot earn from the paywall.

Why does this matter? Because there are hundreds of guides on Gumroad, Amazon Kindle, and YouTube that still teach the pre-August 2023 rules. Readers follow those instructions, apply, get confused when the application asks for a payment method, and assume something has gone wrong. Nothing has gone wrong — the rules simply changed, and the guides did not.

 32K monthly story presentations from a writer with 1,171 followers — distribution is not just for the famous.

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This guide is built entirely on the rules as they exist in 2026. Every step assumes you are starting fresh, that you may have no followers yet, and that you are willing to hold a paid membership as the cost of doing business. That membership fee is the only money you need to spend to begin.

Member vs Friend: The 4× Multiplier

Medium's earnings model does not pay you per view. It pays you based on how long paying readers spend reading your stories. The longer a paying reader stays on your story, the more you earn. This is called read-time-based payouts.

But not all paying readers are worth the same to you as a writer. Medium has two paid reader tiers, and they pass very different amounts of money to writers.

Member tier: \$5 per month, or \$50 per year. This is Medium's standard paid subscription.

Friend of Medium tier: \$15 per month, or \$150 per year. This is the premium subscription. When a Friend of Medium reads your story, approximately four times as much per minute of read time of their subscription dollar passes to you compared to a Member.

 Monthly: \$5 Member, \$15 Friend

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 Annual: \$50 Member, \$150 Friend — saves up to \$30

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Here is a worked example to make this concrete. Suppose you publish a 1,500-word article — roughly a six-minute read. One Member reads it start to finish. One Friend of Medium reads it start to finish. Both spent the same six minutes on your story. But from the Friend's read, you earn approximately four times as much as from the Member's read.

You do not control who subscribes at which tier. What you can control is writing stories that attract and retain engaged readers at any tier. The Friend multiplier is not a strategy — it is a reminder that your earnings are a function of genuine reading time, not clicks or

page views. A reader who opens your story and leaves in thirty seconds earns you almost nothing. A reader who reads to the end earns you far more, regardless of their tier.

The practical implication: write complete, focused stories that readers finish. A 900-word story read fully outperforms a 3,000-word story skimmed for thirty seconds.

The Feb 17, 2026 Conversion Bonus

On February 17, 2026, Medium introduced a new payout mechanic that rewards writers whose stories bring in new paying readers.

Here is how it works. When a non-member — someone browsing Medium without a paid subscription — hits your paywalled story (a story is “paywalled” when it is placed behind Medium’s subscription gate, meaning non-members can only read the first few hundred words), they see a prompt to subscribe. If that reader subscribes to a paid Medium membership during that same browsing session, you receive a conversion bonus on top of whatever you would have earned from that reader’s normal read time.

This is significant because it aligns your earnings with one of Medium’s core business goals: growing its paying subscriber base. Before this change, all paywalled stories were treated equally regardless of whether they converted anyone. Now, stories that actively persuade fence-sitters to subscribe earn more.

The full details are documented in Medium’s official blog post announcing the change: <https://medium.com/blog/partner-program-update-starting-february-17-were-rewarding-stories-that-bring-in-new-members-3e84d2eb6e68>

Medium has not published the exact bonus amount per conversion; it varies by story and is not broken out in the writer dashboard, but it does add a separate line item to the monthly earnings report when conversions occur.

The practical implication for your writing: stories that are genuinely useful to readers who have never paid for Medium — tutorials, clear explainers, answers to specific questions — are more likely to prompt conversions than stories written primarily for existing subscribers. Writing for the uninitiated reader is not just good editorial practice; in 2026, it is also better monetization strategy.

The Boost Program Decline

The Boost Nomination Program still exists in 2026. When a Medium curator “Boosts” a story, that story receives elevated distribution — shown to more readers across the platform. Being Boosted was, through most of 2023 and into early 2024, a meaningful earnings event.

It is now much less so.

The payout bonus attached to a Boosted story has fallen sharply. In 2024, a Boost typically added approximately 30% more earnings on top of a story's organic read-time revenue (based on community reports tracked by Medium writer forums and personal observation). By 2025, that figure had dropped to around 7% by the same measures. In early 2026, following Medium's January 2026 rebalance of its payout algorithm, Boost bonuses fell further. The rebalance shifted weight away from Boost and toward two other signals: base reading time and new-member conversions (the February 17 mechanic described in the previous section).

This does not mean you should write stories that avoid Boost eligibility. A Boosted story still reaches more readers, which means more read time, which means more earnings — just through the standard read-time mechanism rather than through a large bonus multiplier. Being Boosted is still a good outcome.

What it does mean: do not build your income model around the assumption that a handful of Boosted stories will generate significant payouts. The writers who earn consistently on Medium in 2026 are doing so through volume, quality, and conversions — not through Boost lottery wins. This guide will not teach you to optimize for Boost nominations, because that optimization has diminishing returns. It will teach you to build a catalog of stories that earn steadily.

The AI Content Policy in Plain English

Medium has an explicit policy on AI-generated content as of 2026, and it has real consequences for your earnings. Here is what it says in plain terms.

AI-generated text cannot be paywalled, regardless of whether you disclose it. This applies to fully AI-written stories and to stories where AI wrote a substantial portion of the prose.

If you publish AI-generated content without disclosing it, Medium's systems demote that story to "Network only" distribution. Network only means your existing followers can see the story in their feed, but the story does not appear in topic feeds, search results, or anywhere that new readers would discover it. In practice, this cuts off MPP earnings almost entirely — read time from your existing audience alone is rarely significant enough to generate meaningful payouts.

If you disclose that a story is AI-generated, Medium keeps it visible, but it still cannot earn through the paywall. Disclosed AI content can exist on Medium; it simply cannot monetize.

The policy is not a prohibition on using AI tools. It is a prohibition on publishing AI prose as your own writing. The practical distinction:

- Using AI to generate an outline: allowed, no disclosure needed, no earnings impact.
- Using AI to suggest edits to your draft: allowed, no disclosure needed, no earnings impact.
- Using AI to write the sentences and paragraphs: not allowed for paywalled stories.

The writers who try to shortcut this with bulk AI-generated content either see their stories suppressed immediately or earn nothing from paywalled placement. The policy is enforced algorithmically and at the editorial level. Do not build your Medium income strategy around AI-written prose.

Use AI the right way: to help you think through a topic faster, to check your structure, to tighten a paragraph you have already written. Write the prose yourself. This is not just about following rules — stories that read like a human wrote them convert readers and hold attention in ways that AI-smoothed text typically does not.

Real Receipts, Not Hype

Before you invest time building a Medium writing practice, you deserve to see real numbers from a real account — not screenshots of a \$10,000 month from a writer with 500,000 followers.

Here are the numbers from my own account. I have been writing on Medium since 2017. As of April 2026, I have 1,171 followers. My monthly earnings over the eighteen months from October 2024 through April 2026 are shown below.



Real monthly earnings, Oct 2024 → Apr 2026. The honest range is \$16–\$92.

Real monthly earnings, Oct 2024 → Apr 2026. The honest range is \$16–\$92.

The highest single month was \$91.72, in April 2025. The lowest was \$16.02, in October 2024. The most recent month at time of writing — April 2026 — was \$17.35.

What do these numbers mean? A few things worth being clear about.

First, earnings vary from month to month, and individual stories perform unpredictably. A story you think will do well sometimes earns almost nothing. A story you wrote in an hour sometimes earns for months. There is no formula that produces a guaranteed result per story.

Second, the floor here is not zero. Even in a quiet month with no standout stories, the catalog of existing published work continues earning small amounts. Building a catalog is how you build a floor.

Third, the goal of this guide is not \$10,000 per month. The realistic, achievable milestone for a writer who is consistent, writes for humans, and understands the 2026 rules is crossing \$100 per month within six to twelve months. That is the number this book is designed to help you reach. It is a real number, not a viral outlier.

Writers in any of the 100+ countries where the MPP is available can reach this milestone. The platform does not pay differently based on where you live — your earnings depend on how long paying readers anywhere in the world spend on your stories, not on your geography.

What's Next

Chapter 2 covers the four hard eligibility requirements every writer must meet before earning a single dollar from Medium — including the countries where the MPP is and is not available. Before you write a single word for the paywall, it is worth confirming you qualify. The requirements are straightforward, but there are still exclusions that catch writers by surprise. Chapter 2 will walk through each requirement so you can confirm your status before investing time in the writing work that follows.

2 — Eligibility Without Confusion

What This Chapter Covers

- The 4 hard requirements that must all be true before you can apply to the Medium Partner Program in 2026
- Which countries are now supported — including the 77 new countries Medium added in August 2024
- The 6 most common rejection reasons and how to avoid every one of them
- A step-by-step walkthrough of the application form, field by field

The 4 Hard Requirements

To join the Medium Partner Program and start earning, four things must be simultaneously true at the time you apply. Missing any one of them results in rejection, and you then have to wait 30 days before trying again.

1. At least 6 published stories on your profile. Drafts and unlisted stories do not count — only publicly visible, live stories. Aim for 8–10 before applying to give reviewers a comfortable sample and reduce borderline calls.

2. Account active for at least 3 months. The clock starts from account creation, not your first published story. If you created your account years ago and are only now publishing, this requirement is already satisfied. If you are brand new to Medium, create your account today — the count begins immediately.

3. Age 18 or older. Self-reported on the application form. Medium reserves the right to verify and remove accounts that provided a false age.

4. An active paying Medium membership. You must hold a paid membership at the moment you apply and keep it active to keep receiving payouts. Both tiers qualify:

- **Member tier:** \$5 per month or \$50 per year
- **Friend of Medium tier:** \$15 per month or \$150 per year

You do not need the Friend tier to join the MPP — it affects your earnings rate per read (covered in Chapter 1), not eligibility.

One requirement that no longer exists: a follower minimum. Medium removed the 100-follower minimum in August 2023. Any guide still mentioning a follower threshold is teaching rules that have been obsolete for nearly three years. You can apply with zero followers.

Where You Live: 100+ Supported Countries

In August 2024, Medium expanded the MPP to 77 additional countries, bringing the total to more than 100 across six continents. Before that expansion, eligibility was largely limited to English-speaking markets and Western Europe. Writers in Indonesia, Nigeria, the Philippines, and dozens of other countries who were previously excluded can now fully participate.

The underlying infrastructure for payouts is Stripe Express. If your country supports Stripe Express, you can receive MPP earnings. If it does not, you cannot — regardless of your writing quality.

Continent	Sample countries	Notes
Asia	India, Indonesia, Philippines, Malaysia, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Thailand, Singapore, Japan	Majority of the August 2024 expansion; all major markets now covered
Africa	Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa, Egypt, Ghana, Morocco	Six of the continent’s largest economies included
Latin America	Brazil, Mexico, Argentina, Colombia, Chile, Peru	Most of the region now supported
Europe	Most EU countries, UK, Norway, Switzerland, Iceland	Broadly covered since before the 2024 expansion

Continent	Sample countries	Notes
North America	United States, Canada	Supported since the MPP's original launch
Oceania	Australia, New Zealand	Supported since the MPP's original launch

Because Stripe periodically adds countries, the canonical, always-current list is at <https://stripe.com/global>. If your country is not listed today, check back — the trend since 2023 has been consistent expansion.

The 6 Common Rejection Reasons

Medium does not always tell you exactly why your application was rejected.

Understanding the six most common causes lets you audit your own profile before applying, rather than discovering problems after the fact.

1. Not currently a paying Medium member. The most common rejection cause. The application asks for a payment method to verify existing membership — not to charge you. If your membership is expired or you have never subscribed, the application will not go through. Confirm your subscription is active before submitting.

2. Country not supported by Stripe Express. If Stripe Express does not operate in your country, Medium cannot pay you. Check <https://stripe.com/global> before anything else — it is a prerequisite, not a formality.

3. “Insufficient unique value.” This is a vague rejection label that has appeared more frequently since late 2025. In practice it means a human reviewer judged your published stories as derivative: listicles that read like dozens of others, summaries of well-known topics with no original perspective, or content that feels interchangeable with what already exists on the platform. The fix is publishing at least two stories that could not have been written by anyone else — personal experience, specific data you gathered, an analysis grounded in your own professional context.

4. Flagged AI-generated writing. Medium does not accept stories generated entirely by AI. Writers in MPP forums have reported that the AI flag triggers even on lightly edited drafts — uniform sentence rhythm, no first-person specificity, and vague transitions are

the patterns most commonly cited. Revise until the writing has a clear human voice with personal detail before applying.

5. Profile incomplete. No profile photo, no bio, and no pinned story sends a signal that the account is not ready for a professional program. Medium reviewers look at your full profile as context for the application. An anonymous-looking profile with minimal configuration gets rejected at a higher rate than one that looks like a real person is running it.

6. Under 6 stories or under 3 months active. This sounds obvious, but writers occasionally miscount. Unlisted stories, drafts, and responses to other articles do not count as published stories on your profile. Count only standalone stories that a visitor can find by scrolling your profile page. The 3-month clock is from account creation, not first publish, so verify your account creation date in your profile settings if you are close to the line.

The 30-Day Cooldown Trap

A rejected applicant must wait 30 days before reapplying. Submitting again before the window closes results in automatic rejection. A preventable rejection costs you an entire month — which is why the checklist at the end of this chapter matters.

Use the 30-day window productively:

Improve your two weakest stories. Rewrite them with a sharper opening, a more specific personal angle, and a cleaner conclusion. Do not delete and republish — update the existing story to preserve the original publication date.

Fill in every profile gap. Add a profile photo, write a bio, and pin the story you consider your strongest work. These take under an hour and are entirely within your control.

Step-by-Step Application Walkthrough

The application lives at **medium.com/membership/partner-program**. Do not open it until you have confirmed all four eligibility requirements are satisfied.



The Medium Partner Program landing page — your starting point at medium.com/membership/partner-program

*The Medium Partner Program landing page — your starting point at
medium.com/membership/partner-program*

Click “Apply now” from the landing page. Medium may show a brief requirements checklist first — review it, confirm each item applies to your account, then proceed to the form.

 The MPP application form — fields walked through below.

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Email address. Pre-filled from your Medium account. Payout notifications and Stripe onboarding will arrive here. If it is an old address you no longer check, update your Medium account email before starting.

Full legal name. Enter your name exactly as it appears on your government-issued ID — Stripe uses this for identity verification. Nicknames will cause problems at onboarding.

Medium username. Your @handle, pre-filled. Confirms which profile is being evaluated.

Country of residence. Choose the country where you currently live — this must match the country you use when setting up Stripe Express.

Confirmation checkboxes. Two checkboxes: one confirming you are 18 or older, one confirming you agree to the MPP terms. The terms cover earnings calculation, the paying-member requirement, and what happens if your membership lapses — worth a quick read.

Description textarea. This field asks you to introduce yourself and your writing. Write 2–3 short paragraphs: - Paragraph 1: Who you are and what you write about. Be specific. “I’m an Android developer in Lagos writing about mobile UI patterns and building in public” is better than “I write about tech.” - Paragraph 2: What you plan to publish. A consistent niche signals seriousness. - Paragraph 3: Your goal. “I want to build a sustainable writing income alongside my freelance work” is honest and appropriate. You do not need to claim ambition you do not have.

Submit the form. Medium typically reviews applications within a few business days, though the timeline can stretch to two weeks during busy periods. You will receive a decision by email.

Profile Completeness Checklist Before Applying

Run through this checklist the day before you submit your application. Everything here is within your control and costs nothing to fix.

- ☐ **Profile photo uploaded** — a clear image where your face is visible, with a neutral or simple background. It does not need to be professional, but it should be recognizable as a real person.

- ☐ **Bio filled in** — use the formula from Chapter 3: one sentence on who you are, one sentence on what you write, one optional sentence on your background or credibility. Chapter 3 walks through this in detail.
- ☐ **At least 6 stories published** — verify by opening your public profile page in a private browser window and counting visible stories. Aim for 8–10 to give reviewers a comfortable sample.
- ☐ **One story pinned** — your strongest piece should be pinned to the top of your profile. This is the first thing a reviewer sees. If none of your current stories feel strong enough to pin, that is a signal to revise one before applying.
- ☐ **At least one story published in the last 30 days** — based on rejection reports from MPP forums, posting at least one story in the 30 days before applying appears to reduce rejection risk, though Medium has not officially documented this as a requirement. Publishing something recent signals the account is active.

Once all five items are checked, your application is ready to submit.

Next: Chapter 3 covers the Medium profile setup in full — bio formula, niche selection, and how to write a pinned story that does the work of attracting the right readers.

3 — Setting Up Your Profile to Convert

What This Chapter Covers

- The bio formula that tells a visitor in three seconds whether your stories are for them
- Profile photo rules that actually matter versus the ones that do not
- Why pinning a story before you apply to the MPP is one of the highest-impact steps you can do
- How to pick three topic tags that give Medium's recommendation engine something useful to work with

The Bio Formula

Most Medium bios fail in one of two ways. Too short and vague — “Writer. Thinker. Dreamer.” — tells a reader nothing about whether your stories are worth their time. Too long — a 200-word autobiography about your career history, childhood, and current hobbies — and no visitor actually reads it.

A bio has one job: tell a reader who arrives on your profile whether the stories here are for them.

The formula that works is this:

```
[Role] who writes about [topic 1], [topic 2], [topic 3]. [One-sentence hook about what reader gets].
```

[Role] grounds you as a person with a specific vantage point. It does not need to be your job title. “Android developer,” “personal finance hobbyist,” “nurse turned writer” — something concrete, not a generic label.

[topic 1], [topic 2], [topic 3] are the three subjects you write about consistently. These should match the tags on most of your stories, covered later in this chapter.

[One-sentence hook about what reader gets] is the payoff. What will a reader walk away knowing or able to do? Not hype — a concrete benefit.

Three examples across different niches:

Tech: “Software engineer who writes about developer productivity, side projects, and learning in public. If you’re building something on weekends, you’ll find practical tools and honest failure reports here.”

Finance: “Accountant turned personal finance writer covering budgeting, tax basics, and building savings on a single income. Every article includes one thing you can do this week without changing your job or lifestyle.”

Lifestyle: “Runner and slow traveler who writes about training for long-distance races, budget travel in Southeast Asia, and the habits that hold both together. Practical notes from someone who keeps showing up.”

None of these contain inspirational quotes, claims about being passionate, or phrases like “helping people live their best lives.” Those fill space without conveying information.

Common mistake: Bios that run 200 or more words about the writer’s life story get skipped. A visitor spends about three seconds on your bio before deciding whether to scroll. Write for three seconds of attention.

Profile Photo: What Actually Works

Accounts without a photo are read as less trustworthy and less human. You do not need a great photo. You need a photo.

Clear face, neutral background. Your face should be visible and recognizable. A plain wall, outdoor setting without clutter, or simple indoor background all work fine.

Friendly expression. A natural, relaxed expression is all that is required. Most people look better in photos taken mid-conversation than posed stiffly.

Recent — last twelve months. Readers who encounter you across platforms lose trust when your Medium photo looks like a different person. Keep it current.

Selfie cameras are fine. Front-facing cameras on modern phones produce more than enough quality for a profile image. Thirty seconds in good natural light does the job.

Why corporate headshots can backfire. The formal studio headshot with the stiff blazer reads as unapproachable on a writing platform where readers want to hear from someone real. It looks like a LinkedIn profile rather than a writer’s profile. A natural photo almost always performs better.

The one rule that overrides everything: an imperfect photo is better than no photo. A slightly blurry selfie from last month signals a real person. An empty avatar signals a bot.

The Pinned Story Strategy

Your pinned story is the first thing a visitor sees on your profile — and the first thing a Medium reviewer sees when evaluating your MPP application. The pinned slot is not for your most recent story. It is for the story most likely to convince a new reader to follow you.

In practice, numbered listicles in your niche outperform other formats in the pinned position. They are easy to scan, they signal a clear point of view, and they give a reviewer enough variety to assess your writing. A story titled “7 Things I Learned Building My First Side Project” shows more range than a single-perspective essay of the same length.

Pin your strongest story before you apply to the MPP, not after. The reviewer evaluates whatever is pinned at the moment your application lands. Leaving it to chance is an avoidable mistake.

If none of your current stories feel right to pin, that is a clear signal to write one specifically for this purpose before applying. Chapter 4 covers the title formula that makes stories findable. Chapter 5 covers the structure that keeps readers reading. Write one, pin it, then apply.

The sequence: identify or write your strongest story → pin it → apply to the MPP. Do not reverse this order.

Custom Domain (Member Subscription Benefit)

The Member tier (\$5/month or \$50/year) lets you connect a custom domain to your Medium profile. Instead of `medium.com/@yourhandle`, you get `yourname.com`.

Pros: looks more professional, adds a mild SEO signal, builds a personal brand less tied to Medium’s domain. Readers who find you at `yourname.com` have a persistent address you control, regardless of where you publish later.

Cons: requires DNS configuration, costs \$5/month for the membership plus \$10–20/year for the domain, and ties your primary domain to Medium’s infrastructure.

Rule of thumb: not worth setting up until you have earned your first \$100. Before that milestone, the benefit does not justify the cost or time. After \$100, the domain cost is a rounding error and the personal brand value starts compounding. Until then, `medium.com/@yourhandle` works perfectly. Reviewers will not reject you for it.

Picking Your Niche: 3 Topic Tags

Topic tags are the primary signal Medium's algorithm uses to route your stories to readers who have shown interest in those subjects. The question to answer before you start publishing consistently: what three topic tags do you want to be known for?

You can add up to five tags per story, but committing to three as your core identity builds a recognizable pattern. A profile that consistently appears in "Programming," "Career," and "Remote Work" accumulates topic-specific followers faster than one scattered across a dozen unrelated tags.

Pick tags where three conditions are true:

(a) You have lived experience. Not researched familiarity — actual experience. You have shipped code, managed money under real constraints, trained for a race, built something that failed. Readers in any niche can tell the difference between writing from experience and writing from research.

(b) The audience is mid-sized. Giant tags like "Self Improvement" and "Life Lessons" are crowded enough that new writers rarely break through. Tiny tags mean no readers. The sweet spot is a specific tag with an engaged community where a well-written story can reach the top of the recent feed within days. "SwiftUI," "Personal Finance," and "Solopreneurship" are examples of mid-sized tags with active readers.

(c) Boost-eligible publications exist in the niche. Some niches have active publications that regularly nominate stories for Boost. Being published in one gives your stories distribution paths solo publishing cannot match.

Examples: tech writer → Programming, SwiftUI, Side Projects. Finance writer → Personal Finance, Investing, Budgeting. Lifestyle writer → Running, Minimalism, Digital Nomad.

Avoid jumping between niches every few weeks. Medium's algorithm takes several weeks to build a reliable signal for a new writer. Switching tags resets that signal. Pick three and stay with them for at least six months.

Join Existing Publications vs Create Your Own

Medium publications have their own follower bases. When you publish under a publication, your story goes to both your followers and the publication's followers — a distribution multiplier a new writer cannot replicate alone.

Hard rule for beginners: join existing publications for your first six stories. Create your own only after your first \$100/month.

A publication with 40,000 followers gives your story immediate reach that would take a new solo writer years to build. Submitting to publications in your niche — even smaller ones — is one of the few real shortcuts available to writers starting from zero.

After earning \$100/month consistently, your own publication makes sense. You control branding, editorial standards, and can accept submissions from others. At that point, you have enough credibility that building your own channel is worth the setup cost.

A few beginner-friendly publications worth knowing:

The Startup — tech and entrepreneurship, broad scope, high submission volume, well-established distribution.

Better Programming — software development focused, higher quality bar than general tech pubs, strong distribution within developer communities.

The Writing Cooperative — writing craft and the business of publishing. Useful for building an audience of fellow writers who amplify your work.

Personal Growth — habits, self-directed learning, personal development. Large audience, active curation, newcomer-friendly for well-structured stories.

ILLUMINATION — multi-topic, accepts stories across several niches. Known among MPP writers for consistent Boost nominations.

Read submission guidelines carefully before you write for a publication — most specify formatting requirements and topic restrictions. A story written with a specific publication's guidelines in mind is more likely to be accepted than one submitted speculatively.

Next: Chapter 4 covers the title formula — the single piece of craft that determines whether your story gets clicked before anyone reads a word of it.

4 — The Number+Hook Title Formula

What This Chapter Covers

- Why “I” is the single most predictive word in viral Medium titles — and how personal-experience framing changes the math entirely
- Which numbers drive the most clicks, and exactly where the ceiling is before a list looks like clickbait
- The odd-versus-even debate, settled by data — and why the author’s own even-numbered titles consistently outperformed the rule
- Six hook patterns that work across niches, a concrete exercise to produce a working title in under ten minutes, and a one-line terminal check so you never lose clicks to a truncated headline again

Why “I” Wins

When independent writers analyzed viral Medium headlines over 2025 and into 2026, one pattern showed up more consistently than any other: the presence of a first-person pronoun. Not a clickbait phrase. Not a power word. Just “I.”

[An analysis of 100 viral Medium headlines](#) found that personal-experience listicles dominated the top-performing tier. Titles like “10 Things I Learned After Three Years of Writing on Medium” outperformed structurally similar titles without the “I” by a meaningful margin. The pattern repeated across tech, finance, career, and lifestyle niches.

The reason is straightforward: Medium readers are not looking for encyclopedia entries. They are looking for someone who has been through something and is reporting back. “I” signals that someone actual wrote this from experience, not from a keyword research spreadsheet.

This changes the default framing for every number-based title you write. The formula is not just `[N] [items]`. The formula is `[N] [items] I [verb] [context]` — and it is the “I [verb]” clause that does the real work.

Compare these pairs:

- “10 Python Libraries for Data Science” vs “10 Python Libraries I Use Every Week at Work”

- “7 Habits of Productive People” vs “7 Habits That Changed My Output After I Left My 9-to-5”
- “5 Budgeting Mistakes to Avoid” vs “5 Budgeting Mistakes I Made in My First Year of Freelancing”

In each case the second title carries a specific human being’s experience. Readers click on people, not topics.

The Optimal Number Range

Not all numbers are equal. Headline research from [CoSchedule’s analysis of headline formulas](#) consistently shows that 10 is the strongest single number in list headlines. The numbers 5, 7, and 15 follow closely. Below 15, performance is generally strong. Above 20, the title starts reading as hyperbolic — “47 Things Every Developer Should Know” triggers skepticism more than curiosity.

A few practical observations across the range:

3–4: Work for high-confidence, specific claims. “3 Tools I Use to Deploy Faster” signals curation, not padding.

5 and 7: Reliable in nearly every niche — short enough to feel curated, high enough to feel comprehensive.

10: The strongest single number. It maps cleanly to human memory — complete without excessive. When unsure, start here.

12 and 14: Underused by most writers. They work when the number is authentic — when you genuinely found that many things worth discussing, not when you invented items to reach a round count. More on this below.

15–20: Viable when the topic is broad enough. “20 Lessons I Learned in 20 Years” works because the number maps to a milestone.

Above 20: Avoid. “47 Things Every Developer Should Know” triggers skepticism. Numbers above 20 start compensating for thin content rather than signaling it.

The practical rule: pick a number that matches your actual list. Authentic counting beats round-number discipline.

Odd vs Even: The 20% Rule and When to Break It

The standard advice is to use odd numbers. [OptinMonster's analysis of high-performing headlines](#) found that odd-numbered headlines achieve approximately 20% higher click-through rates than even-numbered equivalents. That data is real, and the likely reason is cognitive: odd numbers feel less manufactured than even ones.

But there are two situations where even numbers consistently outperform the rule.

When the even number maps to a genuinely exhaustive list. If you built 12 SwiftUI components over two years and you are writing about all 12 of them, “12 SwiftUI Components” is more credible than “11 SwiftUI Components” or “13 SwiftUI Components.” Readers can sense when a number was chosen for optics versus chosen because that is what the author actually built. Authenticity beats the 20% CTR edge.

When the even number is paired with first-person framing. “12 Things I Use Daily” does not suffer from the even-number CTR penalty in the same way a generic “12 Things Every Developer Needs” would. The “I use” clause does enough credibility work to make the number almost irrelevant — readers are clicking because a person is speaking, not because the number is psychologically optimal.

The author's own publishing history illustrates this clearly, which is the subject of the next section.

Author Case Study: \$67.99 from One SwiftUI Listicle

 Top 3 SwiftUI articles by earnings

Top 3 SwiftUI articles by earnings — note the numbers (12, 14, 10) and the “I use” framing on the third title.

Three articles, all with even numbers (12, 14, 10), all written between 2023 and 2025, account for a meaningful share of total Medium earnings. Here is what each one looked like and why the title worked.

“12 Powerful SwiftUI Components” — \$67.99, 5,800 views, 2,700 reads, 47% read ratio

The 12 was not chosen by keyword research. It was chosen because there were exactly 12 components used in production apps — no invented entries to hit a round number. The 47% read ratio confirms it: readers who clicked stayed through to the end at nearly half the click rate, which is strong for a 2,000+ word listicle. “Powerful” is a claim, and claims invite curiosity — readers want to see whether your definition matches theirs.

“14 Must-Have SwiftUI Code Extensions” — \$66.42, 6,700 views, 3,000 reads, 45% read ratio

Most writers would trim 14 to 12 or round up to 15. The decision to keep it at 14 was simple: there were 14 extensions genuinely worth writing about. “Must-Have” frames the list as curation — someone with real production experience telling you which extensions matter. Similar earnings and read ratio to the first article suggest that in a specific niche, the exact even number matters less than the authenticity behind it.

“10 Swift Extensions I Use All the Time” — \$31.27, 5,100 views, 1,950 reads, 38% read ratio

This is the “I use” frame in its purest form — the title says explicitly that a specific person uses these things, not that they are important in the abstract. The earnings are lower than the SwiftUI pair, not because the title performed worse, but because the audience for plain Swift articles is smaller on Medium than for SwiftUI. The read ratio at 38% is still solid.

The pattern across all three: even numbers plus first-person framing plus niche specificity. None of these titles used superlatives or hype-loaded adjectives. They relied entirely on specificity and personal credibility.

The takeaway is not that odd numbers are wrong — the data showing ~20% higher CTR for odd numbers holds in aggregate. The takeaway is that first-person framing combined with authentic counting consistently overrides that baseline. Write the list you actually have. Name it with the number you actually counted.

The 6 Hook Patterns That Actually Work

These six patterns cover nearly every title situation you will encounter. For each one, the formula is followed by a tech-niche example and a non-tech example — because the formula works across subjects.

1. Usage Hook

Formula: **[N] [items] I Use [daily / every day / in production]**

This is the pattern that powered the “10 Swift Extensions I Use All the Time” result above. The verb “use” anchors the title in practice rather than theory. It signals: this is not a curated list from the internet, this is what one person actually reaches for.

- Tech: “7 VS Code Extensions I Use Every Day on Client Projects”
- Non-tech: “9 Kitchen Tools I Use More Than My Expensive Stand Mixer”

The specificity qualifier — “on client projects,” “more than my expensive stand mixer” — is optional but adds credibility when it fits naturally.

2. Outcome Hook

Formula: [N] [items] That [Saved Me / Changed My / Made Me \$Y]

Outcomes are the second-most powerful hook because they make an implicit promise: read this, get the result. The dollar sign version (\$Y) is particularly effective in finance, freelancing, and side-income niches because it converts the vague promise of “improvement” into a specific, verifiable claim.

- Tech: “5 Refactoring Habits That Cut My Bug Rate in Half Last Quarter”
- Non-tech: “6 Freelance Habits That Made Me \$3,000 Extra This Year Without New Clients”

Do not invent the outcome. If your savings habit did not actually save you money, do not write that it did. Specificity works only when it is true — readers in any niche eventually call out fabricated numbers.

3. Contrarian Hook

Formula: [N] [items] Most [audience] Get Wrong

The contrarian frame works because it flatters the reader — it implies that the reader, by clicking, will learn something that most people miss. The key constraint: you need an actual contrarian position, not just a reframing of conventional wisdom with “wrong” appended.

- Tech: “8 Python Best Practices Most Junior Developers Get Wrong”
- Non-tech: “5 Retirement Planning Rules Most People in Their 30s Get Wrong”

The audience identifier — “junior developers,” “people in their 30s” — makes the contrarian claim land harder by targeting it.

4. Regret Hook

Formula: [N] [items] I Wish I Knew Before [milestone]

Regret titles work because they promise lived experience delivered in a format that lets the reader skip the pain. The milestone gives the title a narrative anchor — “before I launched my first app,” “before my first remote job,” “before I turned 30.”

- Tech: “11 Things I Wish I Knew Before Publishing My First iOS App”
- Non-tech: “7 Money Rules I Wish I Knew Before My First Year of Freelancing”

The first-person “I wish” phrasing is load-bearing. “11 Things New iOS Developers Should Know” is weaker because it lacks the narrative of someone who learned through experience.

5. Secret Hook

Formula: `[N] Underrated [items]` or `[N] Hidden [items]`

This pattern taps into information asymmetry — the reader suspects there are things they do not know, and the title confirms it. “Underrated” works better than “hidden” for tools and techniques; “hidden” works better for features and settings.

- Tech: “6 Underrated Xcode Features That Save Me 30 Minutes a Week”
- Non-tech: “8 Underrated Budget Apps That Actually Work for People Who Hate Budgeting”

Avoid stacking “underrated” with other hype words. “6 Underrated and Powerful and Must-Know Xcode Features” cancels itself out. Pick one modifier.

6. Credibility Hook

Formula: `After [X years/months], Here Are [N] [items]`

The credibility hook works by front-loading tenure — the reader immediately knows they are getting a perspective shaped by experience, not opinion formed from a weekend of research.

- Tech: “After 5 Years of iOS Development, Here Are 10 Tools I Still Use Daily”
- Non-tech: “After 3 Years of Remote Work, Here Are 12 Things I Would Not Give Up”

The number of years or months should be real. “After 5 years” claimed by someone six months into their career gets spotted in the article and destroys trust.

Title Length Rules

The target range is 6 to 12 words and 50 to 70 characters total.

Medium’s mobile feed truncates titles longer than approximately 70 characters. A reader scrolling on a phone sees only the first 70 characters — if the most important part of your title is in characters 71 through 90, it is invisible. Given that mobile accounts for more than half of Medium’s reading traffic, a title that reads perfectly on desktop but gets cut on mobile is a title that is underperforming everywhere.

The word count target (6–12) is a proxy for clarity. Titles shorter than 6 words often lack the specificity to be compelling; titles longer than 12 words tend to either over-explain or bury the lead. The 6–12 range is where most strong Medium titles land naturally.

Before you commit to a candidate title, paste this Python one-liner into your terminal:

```
title = "12 SwiftUI Components I Use Daily"
print f"{len(title.split())} words, {len(title)} chars"
```

Replace the title string with your candidate and run it. If the word count is outside 6–12 or the character count exceeds 70, revise before moving on. This takes about 10 seconds and eliminates one of the most preventable reasons a title underperforms.

A quick example: “12 Underrated SwiftUI Features That Will Make Your Apps Look More Professional in 2026” runs 86 characters — it gets cut mid-sentence on every phone. Trim it to “12 Underrated SwiftUI Features I Wish I Knew Earlier” (53 characters, 9 words) and the full title survives.

The 5-Step Title Exercise

This drill takes less than ten minutes and produces a working title you can commit to. Do it now, before you move to Chapter 5, because the title you write here will shape the structure decisions in the next chapter.

Step 1: Pick a number.

Start with 7, 10, or 12 if you do not have a strong preference. These three numbers have the widest margin for error — they are credible without being either too short to be comprehensive or too long to be believable. Once you have more publishing history, you can fine-tune based on what your actual lists look like.

Step 2: Pick a hook pattern from the six above.

Pick the one that best fits the piece you are about to write. Writing from direct experience with tools you actually use? Start with the Usage Hook. Specific outcome to report? Outcome Hook. Genuine contrarian position? Contrarian Hook.

Step 3: Draft 3 candidate titles using your number and hook pattern.

Write three versions. Do not evaluate while you write — get three candidates on the page first. Vary the specific words, the hook modifier, and the first-person framing between versions. Example for a developer who maintains a mobile app:

- “10 Xcode Shortcuts I Use Every Day to Ship Faster”
- “10 Xcode Features I Use Daily That Most Developers Skip”
- “10 Time-Saving Xcode Tricks I Discovered After Five Years of iOS Work”

Step 4: Run each through the length check.

Paste each candidate into the Python one-liner from the previous section. Flag any that exceed 70 characters and revise them before the next step.

Step 5: Kill 2, commit to 1.

Eliminate two candidates. The surviving title should have the strongest first-person framing and the most specific hook. “I use every day” beats “most developers should know.” “10 Xcode Features I Use Daily That Most Developers Skip” wins over “10 Time-Saving Xcode Tricks I Discovered After Five Years” because the first title names both the author’s practice and the reader’s gap; the second is richer in backstory but buries the benefit.

Write that title at the top of a new document. It is the first line of your article skeleton — which is what Chapter 5 is about.

The title gets a reader to click. The skeleton is what keeps them reading. Chapter 5 covers the structure that carries a 1,500-word article from the first paragraph to the final line without losing the reader in the middle — and without requiring you to outline before you write.

5 — The 7-Part Article Skeleton

What This Chapter Covers

- The seven structural parts every Medium article needs, in order — and why skipping any one of them causes readers to drop off at a predictable point
- Worked examples for each part: what the technique looks like in an actual article, not a hypothetical description
- The most common structural mistake writers make at each part, so you can recognize and fix it before you publish
- Eight niche-specific micro-skeletons — quick-reference outlines for tech listicles, personal essays, tutorials, contrarian pieces, case studies, listicle reviews, how-tos, and stories — that apply the same seven-part logic to different article shapes

Part 1: Opening (3–5 Sentences)

The opening is the only part of your article that every reader sees. Everything after it is conditional. The pattern that works on Medium in 2026 is the same one that worked in journalism fifty years ago: pain → promise → proof. State the pain the reader already feels. Promise the specific thing this article will do about it. Offer a brief proof that you have standing to make that promise.

Here is a worked opening for a hypothetical article titled “8 Xcode Shortcuts I Use Every Day to Ship Faster”:

You open Xcode, and thirty seconds later you are clicking through menus for something you know has a shortcut — you just cannot remember what it is. I spent five years as an iOS developer before I sat down and actually learned the eight commands I now use without thinking. This article is the list I wish I had on day one.

Three sentences: pain, proof, promise. Sentence one names what the reader already experiences. Sentence two delivers the author’s standing to make a claim. Sentence three gives the article’s value in a single line.

Common mistake: Opening with backstory before the pain. Any sentence that begins with vague generic preamble — ‘today,’ ‘with the rise of,’ or any framing that could open ten different articles — is filler. Delete it and start with the reader’s problem.

Part 2: Scannable Subheads

Every 200 to 300 words, your article needs a subhead. This is not aesthetic preference — it is function. Readers on Medium scan before they read. The subheads they see in those first three seconds determine whether they start reading at all. If your article runs 1,500 words with no subheads, a scanner sees a wall of text and moves on.

The format rule is sentence case, not Title Case. “How to set up your environment” reads as a guide. “How To Set Up Your Environment” reads like an SEO attempt from 2014. Medium readers register the difference even if they cannot name it. Sentence case is warmer; Title Case is corporate.

For the same hypothetical Xcode article, four subheads that follow the rules:

- “How I discovered most of these by accident”
- “The eight shortcuts, in the order I learned them”
- “Why the refactoring commands matter more than navigation”
- “How to make any shortcut stick in under a week”

Each subhead either promises information or names a topic the reader can decide to skip or read. None ends with a period. None tries to be clever at the expense of clarity.

Common mistake: Writing subheads as complete sentences with periods. “The navigation shortcuts are the ones most developers learn first.” is a sentence from the article body, not a subhead. Subheads are labels or short promises — they do not end with punctuation.

Part 3: Image Placement

One image per major section is the practical target. For a 1,500-word article with four or five sections, that means four or five images. This does not mean you must have that many — one well-placed image is better than three stock photos that add nothing — but it does mean you should not have a 600-word section with no visual break at all.

Use Unsplash for all images. Unsplash’s license is free for commercial use, including use on paywalled Medium stories. Download the image, host it in your article, and add a caption that includes both a description of what the image shows and a photographer credit in the format: *Photo by [Name] on Unsplash.*

Caption format: *An Xcode project structure showing the file navigator, editor, and debug pane — the three areas covered in sections 2, 5, and 7. Photo by Luca Bravo on Unsplash.* The caption describes what is shown and credits the photographer — two jobs, one line.

Common mistake: Stock-photo clichés — a keyboard, a lightbulb, a generic laptop in a coffee shop. These add no information. If you cannot find an image that genuinely illustrates a section, use a screenshot from your own work, a diagram you made in Excalidraw, or skip the image for that section.

Part 4: Code and Data Blocks

When your article includes code, data, terminal output, or command-line instructions, use triple-backtick fencing with a language tag. Medium renders these as formatted code blocks. Without the language tag, you lose syntax highlighting.

```
```swift
let formatter = DateFormatter()
formatter.dateStyle = .medium
formatter.timeStyle = .none
let label = formatter.string(from: Date())
```
```

The rule is: explain in plain English before you paste the code. Not after. Readers who hit an unexplained code block without context have two options: skip it or close the tab. Neither helps your read ratio. A single sentence before the block — “Here is the formatter setup that handles both the date style and localization in one pass:” — turns a wall of syntax into something the reader understands immediately.

Keep blocks under 30 lines. If you need more than 30 lines to show a concept, split it into two blocks with a sentence between them. A 15-line block with a good explanation reads better than a 60-line block with inline comments.

Common mistake: Pasting 80 lines of code with no narrative. The writer assumes the reader will follow — the reader does not. A tutorial with three focused 15-line blocks outperforms a reference dump with one 100-line block, in both read ratio and earnings.

Part 5: Pull-Quotes

Every article gets one pull-quote maximum. One. Not one per section — one per article.

A pull-quote is a `> blockquote` in Markdown that Medium renders as a visually distinct block. Its purpose is to highlight the single most important sentence in your article — the one sentence you want a skimmer to see and register before they decide whether to start reading from the top.

The ideal length is 12 to 20 words. Long enough to carry meaning on its own; short enough to land in one glance.

From the Xcode article:

The shortcut you use without thinking is the one you learned under pressure, not from a tutorial.

Eighteen words. It stands alone, carries the article's central idea, and gives a scanner a reason to start reading from the top.

Common mistake: Pull-quoting something that is already a heading. If the subhead says “Why refactoring commands matter more than navigation,” do not also blockquote a restatement of that idea. Both devices become weaker. The pull-quote should say something the headings do not — the insight, the claim, the line that earns the read.

Part 6: The CTA

Your article gets exactly one call to action. Choose one of these two options: a link to your most relevant other article, or a link to your newsletter. Not both. One.

The decision between them depends on what the reader needs next. If you have a closely related article — a natural next step in the same subject — link to that. The reader who just finished your Xcode shortcuts article is a candidate for your “8 Swift Extensions I Use in Production” article. Give them the next link.

If you do not have a closely related article yet, link to your newsletter (if you have one). This is the slower path, but it builds a list that is independent of Medium's algorithm.

Place the CTA in the second-to-last paragraph, not the last paragraph. The last paragraph is the article's actual ending — the closing thought, the reflection, the summary. If the CTA is the last thing the reader sees, the article ends on a transaction. That registers as pushy. Put the CTA one step before the end, and let the article end on its own terms.

Common mistake: Stacking CTAs at the bottom — “Subscribe to my newsletter / Follow me on Medium / Buy my course / Share this on Twitter.” Readers click none of these. The more choices you offer, the fewer actions anyone takes. One CTA means one clear direction for the reader who wants to keep engaging with your work. Three CTAs means the reader picks none and closes the tab.

Part 7: Friend-Link Footer

Every published story on Medium should end with a friend-link note. Always. Even stories you think do not need one.

The format is a short note at the very bottom of the article, after the article content has finished. One to two sentences:

Not a Medium member? Read this story for free using my friend link: [paste your friend link URL here]

You generate the friend link from your story's settings panel before publishing. It is a unique URL that lets non-members read your full article without hitting the paywall.

When a non-member reads your story via a friend link and then subscribes during that session, you receive the conversion bonus covered in Chapter 8. Without the friend link, Medium shows the subscribe prompt immediately — before the reader has finished the article. The friend link lets them read first, which converts at a much higher rate.

Common mistake: Omitting the friend link for non-paywalled stories on the grounds that “everyone can already read it.” Non-paywalled stories can still trigger conversion bonuses. Add it to every story, paywalled or not.

8 Niche-Specific Micro-Skeletons

These are quick-reference outlines. They apply the seven-part skeleton to eight common article shapes. Each section header is the part of the article; the one-line description is what goes there. Full templates are in the bonus file — this is the at-a-glance version to reference while drafting.

1. Tech listicle - Hook: Pain or gap the list solves (1–2 sentences) - Why this list now: What made this the right moment to write it - Items 1–N: Consistent format per item — name, what it does, when to use it - Bonus item: The one most readers will not have heard of - Footer: Friend link + one related article link

2. Personal essay - Hook moment: Drop the reader into the scene — no backstory yet - Backstory in 2 lines: Just enough context to make the scene make sense - The conflict: What was at stake or what had to be decided - The choice: What you actually did - The lesson: What it taught you that you did not expect - Reflection: How you think about it now

3. Tutorial - Outcome promise: Exactly what the reader will have working at the end - Prerequisites: What the reader needs before starting (versions, tools, accounts) - Step 1: First action — command, click, or concept - Step 2: Second action - Step 3: Third action (add more steps as needed, keep each focused) - Verify it worked: How to confirm the outcome was achieved - Troubleshooting: Two or three common failure points and fixes

4. Contrarian opinion - The widely-held belief: State it fairly — do not strawman it - Why it is wrong: Your specific objection, not a vague alternative - Evidence: Data, personal experience, or cited source that supports your objection - What to do instead: The concrete alternative you are recommending - Caveat: Where the conventional wisdom still holds — this is what makes the piece credible

5. Case study - Subject and situation: Who or what this is about, and the starting context - The before state: Measurable or observable condition before the change - What was done: The specific actions taken, in order - The after state: Measurable or observable result - Lessons: What this tells us that generalizes beyond this one case - How to apply it: One or two steps the reader can take based on this case

6. Listicle review (book or tool round-up) - Why this round-up: What gap this fills that other lists do not - Criteria: How you evaluated each item — be specific - Item 1 through N: For each — verdict in one sentence, then when to use it - Final verdict: If you could only pick one item from the list, which and why

7. How-to - Problem: The specific situation the reader is in - Promise: The exact thing they will be able to do after reading - Step 1: First action - Step 2: Second action - Step 3: Third action (extend as needed) - Result: What the completed outcome looks like - Variations: Alternate paths for common edge cases

8. Story - Situation: Where and when — set the scene in one or two sentences - Conflict: What went wrong, what was missing, or what created pressure - Choice: What decision was made at the turning point - Outcome: What actually happened as a result - Lesson: The single thing this story demonstrates that the reader can take away

Chapter 6 takes the skeleton you have now and puts it on a calendar. The 14-day plan covers exactly which article type to write first, how many hours to budget per piece, and how to sequence your initial catalog so that each new story builds on the last — rather than sitting as an isolated post with no internal links. The micro-skeleton that fits your niche is already in this chapter; Chapter 6 is where you schedule it.

6 — Your First Article in 14 Days

What This Chapter Covers

- A day-by-day plan that takes you from blank page to published article in two weeks
- Why building in a rest day is not optional — it is the mechanism that makes your edits work
- What to do when a publication rejects your submission
- The five mistakes beginners almost always make in the first two weeks

The 14-Day Plan At A Glance

| Day | Focus | Time | Output |
|-----|---|--------|---|
| 1 | Pick niche + target publication | 1 hr | Niche choice locked, 3 publications shortlisted |
| 2 | Brainstorm 10 title candidates (use Ch 4 formula) | 45 min | List of 10 titles, picked 1 |
| 3 | Outline using Ch 5 skeleton | 1 hr | 7-section outline filled in |
| 4 | Write opening + first 2 sections | 1 hr | ~600 words drafted |
| 5 | Write middle 3 sections | 1 hr | ~700 more words drafted |
| 6 | Write closing + CTA + friend-link footer | 45 min | Full draft complete |

| Day | Focus | Time | Output |
|-----|---|--------|------------------------|
| 7 | REST DAY — do not touch the draft | 0 min | Distance gained |
| 8 | Edit pass 1 — structure (does the flow work?) | 1 hr | Restructured if needed |
| 9 | Edit pass 2 — line edit (every sentence earns its place) | 1 hr | Tightened draft |
| 10 | Source images from Unsplash, add captions + credits | 30 min | Images placed |
| 11 | Format in Medium editor, add Friend Link, preview mobile | 1 hr | Ready to submit |
| 12 | Submit to chosen publication via their submission form | 15 min | Submitted |
| 13 | While waiting — draft your second article's title | 15 min | Title #2 ready |
| 14 | Published — share on ONE platform (Twitter or LinkedIn, not both) | 15 min | Published + shared |

The total active time across all 14 days is roughly 10.5 hours. That is less than a single work day. Most people who fail at Medium do not fail because they lack time — they fail because they try to do all 10.5 hours on a single weekend and burn out.

The plan is designed to fit into the gaps of a busy week. Days 1–6 are writing days. Day 7 is a forced pause. Days 8–11 are editing and production. Days 12–14 are the finish line.

Why The Rest Day Matters (Day 7)

When you finish the first draft on Day 6 and walk away, something useful happens: you stop being the writer and start becoming the reader. The version of you who returns on Day 8 will see things the Day 6 version could not. A paragraph that felt essential when you wrote it will reveal itself as throat-clearing. A section you rushed through will show a gap where an example belongs. You cannot manufacture this distance — you can only wait for it.

There is also a less obvious benefit. While you are not consciously working on the article, your brain keeps processing the structure. Writers who report waking up with a sudden solution to a structural problem they could not solve the night before are not exaggerating. The rest day is not a break from the work — it is a different kind of work that happens without your involvement.

The third reason to stay away from the draft on Day 7 is more practical: early drafts invite over-editing. When the ink is still wet, every sentence feels like it could be better, and you end up rewriting the same paragraph four times without improving it. The 24-hour gap breaks that loop. You return with better judgment, not just fresh eyes.

What If The Publication Says No?

A rejection from a Medium publication is one of the most common experiences for new writers. It does not mean your article is bad. Most editors reject submissions because the piece does not fit the publication's current focus or tone — not because the writing itself failed.

Here is the three-step recovery plan:

1. Don't take it personally — most editors reject for fit, not quality. Publication editors are curators, not judges. They are building a collection with a consistent voice and topic focus. Your article about developer productivity might be excellent writing and still get a no from a publication that has just run three similar pieces. The rejection is about inventory management, not your skill.

2. Re-pitch elsewhere — submit the same draft to a different Boost-eligible publication. You do not need to rewrite the article. Copy the same draft and submit it through another publication's submission form. Chapter 7 covers how to find Boost-eligible publications and how to read their submission guidelines so you can target the right ones. One article can be submitted sequentially — one at a time — until it finds a home.

3. Self-publish under your own profile. If two or three publications pass, stop waiting and publish the article yourself. Add three tags from your niche, enable Friend Link before you hit publish, and share it once. Articles published without a publication still earn from the Medium Partner Program as long as you are enrolled and the article is metered. Publication curation helps with distribution, but it is not a requirement for earning.

What If You Miss A Day?

Don't restart the 14 days.

If you miss Day 4, your new Day 4 is tomorrow. Everything shifts forward by one day. The plan is a sequence of steps, not a calendar with fixed dates. What matters is that you complete each step in order — not that you do it on a specific day of the month.

This matters because the alternative — restarting from scratch — almost always leads to never finishing. You end up cycling through Days 1 and 2 repeatedly, picking a new niche or a new title, without ever completing a draft. Forward momentum is worth more than a clean schedule.

If life pulls you away for an entire week, shift the whole plan forward by seven days and continue from where you stopped. The draft you have is still valid. The outline you made is still good. Pick up the pen where you put it down.

Common Mistakes In The First 14 Days

- **Spending Day 1 and Day 2 picking the “perfect” niche.** There is no perfect niche — there is only the niche you know enough about to write something useful today. Pick one and lock it. You can always write in a different niche next month.
- **Writing on Day 1 without an outline.** A blank document and no structure leads to a wandering draft that is painful to edit later. Spend Days 1–3 on preparation. The actual writing goes faster when the outline exists.
- **Skipping the rest day.** Day 7 is in the plan for a reason. Editing a draft you finished 12 hours ago is like proofreading your own work immediately after writing it — your brain autocorrects what should not be corrected and misses what should be fixed. Honor the pause.
- **Submitting to 5 publications simultaneously.** Most Medium publications have anti-multi-submit rules, and editors talk to each other in niche communities. Submit to one publication at a time. Wait for a response (or 7 days of silence, which is effectively a

soft no) before moving to the next.

- **Posting on social media every day waiting for views.** Post once when the article goes live, then close the tab. Checking your stats every few hours does not move the number. Writing your next article does. The compounding effect that makes Medium worthwhile comes from having 20 articles working for you simultaneously, not from refreshing the dashboard on article one.
-

Now that you have a concrete publishing plan, the next logical question is where to publish. Chapter 7 covers Medium publications in detail — how to find the ones that accept submissions, how to read their guidelines without guessing, and how to write a pitch that editors actually respond to. Getting into the right publication shortens the path to your first Boost significantly.

7 — ***Publications: Pitch & Get In***

What This Chapter Covers

- What a Medium publication is and why getting into one is the biggest distribution lever a beginner has
- The three publication tiers — free-to-submit, curation-based, and invitation-only — and which to target first
- A reference table of 30 publications across niches with submission style and Boost eligibility
- The exact pitch email template, a worked example, and the 5 mistakes that get writers blacklisted

What A Publication Is And Why It Matters

A Medium publication is a curated collection of stories built around a niche or editorial voice. When an editor accepts your story, it gets distributed to two audiences you could not reach alone: the publication's followers and the topic feeds the publication contributes to.

A writer with 200 followers who publishes solo reaches a few hundred readers on a good day. That same article, accepted by a publication with 50,000 followers, lands in front of a ready audience that already trusts the brand.

For most beginners, getting into the right publication is the highest-impact move in the first three months. It does not replace writing quality — editors spot thin content — but it solves the cold-start problem that kills otherwise good articles.

Stories outside publications still earn. The Medium Partner Program pays based on read time wherever a story lives. But without publication distribution, volume depends entirely on your follower count and whatever traffic you drive yourself. If you are new, that means slow feedback and low early earnings.

Write the article first, then pitch publications. If two or three pass, publish it yourself. But always try at least one publication before self-publishing.

The 3 Publication Tiers

Tier 1 — Free-to-submit publications

Open submission, no formal editorial review. Turnaround is typically 24–72 hours. Examples: ILLUMINATION, Write A Catalyst. Distribution is smaller and Boost nomination rates are lower, but these are the right starting point if you have no publication credits yet. Acceptance builds the track record that Tier 2 editors look for.

Tier 2 — Curation-based publications

Submissions go through a Google Form or similar. Editorial staff review for niche fit, formatting, and writing quality. Turnaround is 3–7 days, sometimes two weeks for high-volume publications. Examples: Better Programming, In Plain English, UX Collective, ITNEXT, Level Up Coding. Distribution reach and Boost nomination rates are higher than Tier 1. Once you have two or three published pieces, this tier should be your main focus.

Tier 3 — Invitation-only publications

No cold form submissions accepted. Writers are invited by editors or apply through specific writer programs. Examples: Better Humans, the invitation tier of The Startup. Build a consistent record in Tiers 1 and 2, get Boosted, and invitations tend to follow. You can also pitch directly via email — the template for that is in the next section.

The Top 30 Paying Publications (2026)

| Name | Niche | Submission style | Boost-eligible | N |
|--------------------|-------------------|------------------|----------------|----------------------------|
| Better Programming | Tech/software | Curation (form) | Y | V
t
s
d
a |
| The Startup | Business/startups | Invitation | Y | S
t
o
N
k
P |
| In Plain English | General/tech | Curation (form) | Y | F
n |

| | Name | Niche | Submission style | Boost-eligible | Notes |
|--|-----------------------------|-------------------|------------------|----------------|----------------------------|
| | | | | | h
a |
| | ILLUMINATION | General writing | Free (open) | Y | F
t
g
p
c |
| | Better Humans | Self-improvement | Invitation | Y | I
b
b
p |
| | UX Collective | Design/UX | Curation (form) | Y | T
P
M
s
n
h |
| | JavaScript in Plain English | JavaScript | Curation (form) | Y | P
P
f
s |
| | ITNEXT | Developer-focused | Curation (form) | Y | S
L
b
c |
| | Level Up Coding | General dev | Curation (form) | Y | E
d
a
t
p
h |
| | AI in Plain English | AI/ML | Curation (form) | Y | F
p |

| Name | Niche | Submission style | Boost-eligible | Notes |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|----------------|-----------------------|
| | | | | Platform |
| Write A Catalyst | Writing/personal growth | Free (open) | Y | Consistent |
| The Writing Cooperative | Writing craft | Curation (form) | Y | ceptual |
| Mind Cafe | Mental health/mindfulness | Curation (form) | Y | Life perspective |
| The Ascent | Personal development | Curation (form) | Y | Practical application |
| Towards Data Science | Data science/ML | Invitation/application | Y | Focus on platform |
| HackerNoon on Medium | Tech/startups | Curation (form) | N | Highly competitive |

| | Name | Niche | Submission style | Boost-eligible | Notes |
|--|------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------|----------------|---------------|
| | Python in Plain English | Python | Curation (form) | Y | Pop fiction v |
| | Towards AI | AI/ML research | Curation (form) | Y | Facebook |
| | The Bold Italic | San Francisco/lifestyle | Invitation | N | Facebook cap |
| | Personal Growth | Self-improvement | Free (open) | Y | Facebook |
| | The Post-Grad Survival Guide | Career/finances | Curation (form) | Y | SnZ |
| | Entrepreneurship Handbook | Entrepreneurship | Curation (form) | Y | Facebook |
| | DataDrivenInvestor | Finance/investing | Curation (form) | Y | Pop fiction v |
| | Curious | General interest/science | Curation (form) | Y | Eda |

| Name | Niche | Submission style | Boost-eligible | Notes |
|---------------|--------------------------|------------------|----------------|--------------------|
| | | | | See below |
| Elemental | Health/wellness | Invitation | N | Value added |
| Forge | Productivity/work | Invitation | N | Value added |
| MakeItNew | Creativity/design | Curation (form) | Y | Content production |
| Startup Grind | Startups/founder stories | Curation (form) | Y | File links |
| Publishous | General writing | Free (open) | Y | Content pipeline |
| CodeX | Programming/tutorials | Curation (form) | Y | Content |

Note: Boost eligibility changes as editorial programs evolve. Verify the current status by checking each publication's submission page before submitting.

The Pitch Email Template

For Tier 3 publications, send a direct email pitch before submitting the draft. A brief, well-structured pitch shows you understand the publication's standards and respect the editor's time.

Subject line formula: `Pitch: [Article Title] for [Publication Name]`

Body template:

Para 1 — Who you are (1–2 sentences): *I'm [name], a [role/niche] writer who has been publishing on Medium since [year]. [One credibility marker: recent publication credit, Boost nomination, or specific stat.]*

Para 2 — The article (2–3 sentences): *I'd like to pitch "[Article Title]" for [Publication Name]. The piece covers [core topic] through the angle of [specific hook], which fits your audience because [one reason — reference a recent pub piece or their stated focus]. The draft is approximately [word count] words.*

Para 3 — Soft ask (1–2 sentences): *Happy to revise before submission — let me know if the angle needs adjusting. Working draft: [link].*

[Full name] | Medium: @[handle] | [Portfolio link]

Worked example — developer niche:

Subject: *Pitch: "Why I Stopped Using Redux and What I Use Instead" for Better Humans*
Hi [editor name],

I'm Jeri, an iOS and web developer based in Indonesia, publishing on Medium since 2017. My last article was accepted by Better Programming and received a Boost nomination in October.

I'd like to pitch "Why I Stopped Using Redux and What I Use Instead" for Better Humans. The piece is a real before-and-after refactor on a production React app — code examples, a time breakdown, and a clear verdict — not a theoretical comparison. The draft is approximately 1,400 words. Happy to revise before formal submission. Working draft: [link].

Jeri P.M. | Medium: @jeripm | jrdevhub.com

The credibility marker is specific ("nominated in October"), the article description leads with what makes it different, and the close has no deadline pressure. Editors respond better to collaborators than applicants.

Submitting Via Form (Free + Curated Publications)

For Tier 1 and Tier 2 publications, submissions go through a Google Form or Medium's built-in interface. Most rejections come from skipping preparation, not from weak writing.

Read the “Write For Us” page top-to-bottom. It lists acceptable topics, word count ranges, image specs, tag counts, and topics currently oversupplied. The most common avoidable rejection is submitting something the publication has just run three versions of.

Match formatting requirements exactly. Header image dimensions, tag count, subheading style — these signal whether you read the guidelines. Editors notice.

Submit one story per publication at a time. Most publication editors are unpaid volunteers. Flooding the queue flags your name. Submit one, wait, then send the next.

Allow 2–7 days before following up. If no response window is listed, two to seven business days is standard. One follow-up after that window is fine. Daily follow-ups are not.

How To Get A Boost

The Boost Nomination Program gives publication editors the ability to nominate stories for extra distribution across Medium's topic feeds. Nominations directly increase read time and therefore earnings.

In 2024, a single Boost could add significant read-time volume to a story. In 2026 the per-story impact is smaller — the program expanded and the boost distributes more broadly. It still matters: a Boosted story in a strong publication reaches meaningfully more readers than the same story without one.

What tends to get nominated: an original perspective the publication has not run recently, a strong opening (not a rhetorical question, not a definition), a clear takeaway the reader can act on, and formatting that works on mobile — short paragraphs, subheadings that preview rather than label.

What gets passed over: reformatted blog posts, generic listicles without original source material, and writing where the author's voice is absent.

Official reference: <https://help.medium.com/hc/en-us/articles/26729526741399-Boost-Nomination-Program-Participation>

The 5 Don'ts

1. Spamming editors with daily follow-ups. One follow-up after the stated window is professional. Daily follow-ups get you remembered, and not in a good way. Editors within publication networks talk to each other.

2. Submitting the same draft to multiple publications simultaneously. Most publications ask for first consideration. If you send one draft to five publications at once and three accept it, you have a problem you caused yourself. Submit sequentially.

3. Pretending to be in a niche you are not. Editors check your Medium profile before responding. If your history is iOS development and you pitch personal finance calling yourself a “personal finance writer,” the mismatch is obvious. Write in your actual niche, or be transparent about expanding.

4. Submitting AI-generated body text as original writing. Editors who read hundreds of submissions per month develop a fast intuition for text that does not sound like a person wrote it. Most publications explicitly ban AI-generated content. Getting caught risks rejection across the network, not just one publication.

5. Joining clap-trade or follow-trade groups. Medium’s algorithm detects coordinated engagement patterns, and trades do not convert to earnings the way organic reading does. High clap counts on articles with low read-time ratios are also a flag for publication editors reviewing future submissions.

Chapter 8 covers what happens after your story is published. The relationship between read time, member tier, and payout timing is less obvious than it looks — and misunderstanding it is why many writers quit in the first month when the numbers look smaller than expected.

8 — Engagement Mechanics

What This Chapter Covers

- How Medium actually calculates your earnings in 2026 — the three inputs and which one dominates
- Why a story with 1,000 claps can earn less than a story with 100 claps, and what that means for how you write
- How to use Friend Links to turn non-members into engaged readers — and sometimes new subscribers
- The seven things that will get your account flagged or banned, and the five habits that build a durable writing presence

How Earnings Are Actually Calculated

Medium does not publish a per-read-minute rate or a fixed price for anything. What it does publish is a clear description of the three inputs that determine how a story earns inside the Medium Partner Program.

As of 2026, those three inputs are:

Member read time is the primary driver. Every minute a paying Medium member (or Friend) spends reading your paywalled story contributes to your earnings pool. Read time is tracked at the individual-session level, not by page view. A reader who opens your article, reads the whole thing, and closes the tab earns you more than ten readers who click and bounce within ten seconds.

Engagement points — claps, highlights, and responses — act as signals, not as direct revenue. Medium's distribution algorithm uses engagement to decide which stories to surface in the topic feeds and the daily digest. More surface area means more readers, which means more read time. But claps themselves do not have a cash value attached.

Boost multiplier is applied when a story is Boost-nominated by a Medium editor (covered in Chapter 7). A Boost nomination increases distribution significantly and can multiply the read-time earnings a story generates in the first week after publication.

The official breakdown is here: [Calculating earnings in the Partner Program](#)

The practical takeaway is this: optimize for stories people finish. A story that earns consistent, high-quality read time from 300 readers will outperform a story that gets 2,000 quick views with a 15-second average read time. Distribution matters, but distribution without retention does not pay.

Read Time vs Claps: The 2026 Weighting

Claps are easy to give. One reader can send up to 50 claps in a single session by holding down the applause button. That mechanic makes clap counts an unreliable proxy for genuine engagement.

Read time is much harder to inflate. A reader either spends five minutes on your article or they do not.

Here is a concrete example. Suppose you publish two stories:

- Story A: 1,000 claps, 200 reads, average read time 90 seconds.
- Story B: 100 claps, 500 reads, average read time 6 minutes.

Story B earns more. The clap count on Story A looks impressive in a screenshot, but the actual minutes of member read time delivered by Story B are substantially higher, and that is what the Partner Program pays against.

This has a direct implication for how you structure your writing. Two-minute hot takes — strong take, short execution, quick scroll — can get claps and followers. They do not build meaningful read-time earnings. Articles in the 5–10 minute range give members enough to engage with, and if the writing is good, they finish. That is where the income comes from.

Do not pad articles artificially. A 3,000-word piece that loses the reader at paragraph four earns about the same as a 600-word piece — a lot of bounce and a short session. The goal is stories long enough to matter and tight enough to finish.

Friend Links: How To Use Them

Every story you publish behind the paywall automatically gets a Friend Link. You can find it in the share menu of the story: look for the option labeled “Friend Link” and copy the URL.

A Friend Link lets a non-member read your paywalled story for free. The important part: their read time still counts toward your earnings. Medium tracks the session and credits you as if a member had read it.

This removes the “paywall wall” problem. When you share a story on Twitter, LinkedIn, a newsletter, or in a message, sharing the paywalled URL means non-members hit a hard stop and bounce. Sharing the Friend Link means they read the full article.

Add this line to the footer of every story before you publish it:

Not a Medium member? Read this story for free using my friend link: [URL]

That line does several things. It removes friction for non-members. It signals that you are a working writer who understands the platform. And it gives curious readers a path to the full content, which increases the chance they finish the article — which feeds directly into read-time earnings.

There is a compounding benefit too. When a non-member reads a Friend Link story and finds the content good enough to want more, they sometimes convert to a paid membership. That triggers a separate earning mechanic, which the next section covers.

The New-Member Conversion Bonus (Feb 17, 2026)

Starting February 17, 2026, Medium added a bonus payment for writers whose stories bring in new paying members.

The mechanic works like this: if a non-member reads your paywalled story — including via Friend Link — and signs up for a paid Medium membership during that same session, you receive a one-time conversion bonus on top of the normal read-time earnings the story generates.

The official announcement is here: [Partner Program update — starting February 17, we’re rewarding stories that bring in new members](#)

From a practical standpoint, this creates a three-layer earning opportunity from a single story:

1. Read-time earnings from the member who just converted.
2. Read-time earnings from every future member who reads that story.
3. The one-time conversion bonus attached to the new signup event.

To make this happen regularly you need three things at the same time: a Friend Link being circulated outside Medium so non-members can reach the story, a paywalled story they can convert through, and writing good enough to make someone decide that a \$5/month membership is worth it right now. None of those three alone is enough, but together they work.

The 7 Things NOT To Do

These are not edge cases or gray areas. Each one carries a real risk of account suspension, MPP removal, or permanent ban.

Join clap-trade groups. These are communities — usually on Telegram or Discord — where members agree to clap on each other's stories in exchange for return claps. Medium's trust-and-safety team monitors for coordinated engagement patterns, and writers who are reported or flagged by the system risk having their accounts suspended.

Use sock-puppet accounts to inflate claps. Creating secondary accounts to clap on your own work violates Medium's terms of service. Accounts get terminated when this pattern is detected, and both the secondary and primary account can be removed.

Pay for views via traffic services. Third-party “send 10,000 views to your article” services are detectable through referrer patterns and session data. Medium treats purchased traffic as manipulation. The story can be de-distributed and the account flagged.

Submit plagiarized content. DMCA takedowns happen. When Medium receives a valid copyright complaint, the story is removed and the writer's MPP eligibility can be revoked. This applies to repurposed AI output that copies source material as well as to traditional plagiarism.

Ignore AI-disclosure rules. Medium requires that stories substantially generated by AI tools include a disclosure. Stories that do not include one are restricted to “Network only” distribution — they do not appear in topic feeds or the digest, which means no organic reach and effectively no earnings. The disclosure requirement is not punitive; it is just a platform rule that directly affects distribution.

Spam follower-back DMs after every new follow. Sending automated or semi-automated “Thanks for following, here are my 10 best articles” messages to new followers consistently gets reported as spam. It damages your brand among the writers and readers who matter most.

Comment-spam on others' articles to drive traffic. Leaving thin, promotional comments — “Great piece! I wrote something similar, check it out” — on popular articles is one of the fastest ways to get blacklisted by editors. Editors share notes. Writers who do this reliably get submission rejections without explanation.

The 5 Healthy Habits

These do not require any tool or automation. They are just practices that compound over time.

Reply to every comment in the first 24 hours after publishing. The window immediately after publication is when your story has the most algorithmic momentum. Responses signal active engagement and show new readers that you are present. A story with a genuine conversation in the comments also holds attention longer than one with none.

Clap genuinely on others' work in your niche. When you read something good, send 15–50 claps. For solid work that did not quite land for you, 1–15 is honest. The goal is not reciprocity farming — it is building familiarity with writers whose audiences overlap with yours. Over weeks, they notice.

Follow 3–5 writers in your niche per week. Keep the circle focused. A small, tight network of writers who write about related topics will surface your work to each other's readers naturally through responses and mentions. A large, unfocused follow list does not do this.

Write one thoughtful response per week to a popular article in your niche. A response that adds something — a counterpoint, a real example, a missing nuance — shows up in that author's story as a top-level comment. Their readers see it. Some of them click your name and land on your profile. This is slow traffic, but it is high-quality traffic from people already interested in exactly what you write about.

Always share Friend Links, not paywalled URLs, when promoting your own work outside Medium. This applies everywhere: your Twitter posts, your LinkedIn shares, your newsletters, your personal website, your messages to colleagues. A paywalled link loses non-members at the wall. A Friend Link delivers the full article. Given that Friend Link reads count toward your earnings and can trigger conversion bonuses, there is no reason to share the raw paywalled URL.

Chapter 9 covers what happens after you have started earning: setting up Stripe Express to actually receive your payments, what the payout thresholds are, and which countries have access to what options — including the workarounds that matter for writers based in Indonesia and other markets where Stripe Express has partial or delayed support.

9 — *Stripe Payout Worldwide*

What This Chapter Covers

- Why Medium uses Stripe Express specifically — and what that means for how you connect your bank account
- The exact setup steps, the tax forms you will be asked to complete, and what goes wrong and why
- How currencies, exchange rates, and the \$10 minimum threshold interact with your actual cash flow
- What to do if Stripe rejects your bank, and a simple tracking template that doubles as a tax log

Why Stripe Express

Medium does not process payouts itself. The Partner Program uses Stripe Express to handle the entire payment flow — identity verification, tax document collection, bank account management, and fund disbursement.

Stripe Express is a hosted onboarding product Stripe provides specifically for marketplace platforms. When you set up Medium payouts, you are connecting to a Stripe Express account that Medium creates on your behalf. You do not need a separate Stripe account first. If you already have one for another business, it does not matter here — the two are completely separate.

The important consequence of this architecture: when something goes wrong on the Stripe side — a bank rejection, an identity verification flag, a tax form issue — Medium support cannot fix it. Those issues go to Stripe Express support directly, via the dashboard link in your Express account.

The canonical reference for Stripe Express is: <https://stripe.com/express>

Setup Steps

Have your official ID and bank account details ready before you start. The process can complete instantly or pause for manual identity verification — having everything on hand avoids having to restart.

1. Sign in to Medium with the account enrolled in the Partner Program.
2. Go to **Settings** → **Payouts**. If you do not see Payouts in the menu, confirm your account is enrolled in the Medium Partner Program first (covered in Chapter 2).
3. Click **Connect to Stripe**.
4. Choose your **country of residence** from the list. This must be a country where Stripe Express is supported. The full list of supported countries was reviewed in Chapter 2. Your payout currency and available bank options depend on this selection, so choose accurately — you cannot easily switch countries later without contacting support.
5. Enter your **legal name** exactly as it appears on your official government-issued ID. Middle names, diacritics, abbreviated names — match the ID. Mismatches here cause identity verification to fail.
6. Enter your **date of birth** and your **tax identification number** appropriate for your country. For US writers this is your SSN or EIN. For non-US writers it may be your national tax ID, personal identification number, or in some countries, a passport number. If your country does not use tax IDs in the traditional sense, Stripe will guide you to the appropriate field.
7. Enter your **bank account details**: account number, routing number or IBAN/SWIFT depending on your country, and confirm the account is in your name and in the country you selected in step 4.
8. Complete **identity verification** if Stripe requests it. This usually means uploading a photo of a government-issued ID — passport, national ID card, or driver's license. Stripe's verification system handles the review.
9. Wait for **verification to complete**. This is often instant for low-complexity cases. For accounts in certain countries or with edge cases in the document review, it can take 1–3 business days. You will receive an email when it is done.

After verification, your Stripe Express dashboard becomes accessible from Medium's Payouts page. That dashboard is where you can check your balance, update your bank account, download tax documents, and reach Stripe support.

Tax Documents By Region

Tax forms are collected during onboarding and sometimes updated annually. What you fill out depends entirely on where you are based.

US writers complete a **W-9** during onboarding. If your earnings exceed \$600 in a calendar year, you will receive a 1099-NEC reporting that income to the IRS. Keep your own records throughout the year — the 1099 confirms the number but you want a log to verify it.

Non-US writers complete a **W-8BEN** during onboarding. The W-8BEN declares your foreign tax status and lets you claim a tax treaty benefit if one exists between your country and the US. Without a treaty, Medium withholds 30% of your earnings before paying you. With a valid treaty claim, that rate drops — often to 0–15%. Look up your country's treaty with the US on the IRS website before completing the form. For Indonesian writers, the US–Indonesia treaty reduces withholding on this income type to 10–15%.

EU writers: VAT is not collected by Medium on your Partner Program earnings. Declare income as personal or freelance income per your country's rules. Check whether your Medium earnings, combined with other freelance income, push you past your local VAT registration threshold (typically €10K–€50K depending on the country).

All other regions: declare Medium earnings as personal income per your local rules. If your country has a US tax treaty, claim it on your W-8BEN. Export your Medium earnings history regularly rather than relying on platform records alone at tax time.

Currencies And Exchange

Stripe Express defaults to USD payouts globally. Medium pays into your Stripe Express account in USD; Stripe then transfers to your bank. If your bank account is in a local currency, the conversion happens at the bank level on the day of transfer. Bank exchange rates include a 1–3% margin over the interbank rate — sometimes wider.

For writers in stable-currency countries — UK, EU, Australia, Singapore — this is a minor friction. For writers in high-volatility currencies — Argentine peso, Turkish lira, Nigerian naira, Pakistani rupee — converting at the bank's rate on transfer day can erode real value quickly during periods of depreciation.

The workaround: receive into a multi-currency wallet instead of a local-currency bank account. Wise and Revolut both support Stripe Express deposits in most of their operating countries and let you hold balances in USD, converting on your own schedule. This puts the timing of the exchange in your hands. Check the Stripe Express dashboard for what is available in your country before you set this up.

Some countries support native local-currency payout through Stripe Express — check your dashboard after onboarding. If that option exists and your currency is stable, it removes the conversion step entirely.

The \$10 Minimum + Rolling 30 Days

Medium only initiates a payout when your accumulated balance crosses \$10. If you earn \$7.20 in a month, that balance rolls forward and combines with next month's earnings. The threshold applies to your total outstanding balance, not to a single month in isolation.

The "rolling 30 days" calculation works at the story level: for each story, Medium counts member read time from the preceding 30 days at any given point. A story that goes modestly viral does not pay you once and stop — every day it earns based on whoever read it in the previous 30 days. A story from November can still be adding to your January balance if readers keep finding it.

This means you cannot predict a month's payout from what you published that month. You are collecting earnings from a rolling window across all your stories. A story you published six months ago with steady search traffic may be contributing more than your most recent piece — older content compounds quietly. Balances below \$10 carry forward indefinitely with no expiration.

Payout Calendar

Medium runs its payout cycle around the 5th of each month — sometimes the 4th, sometimes the 6th or 7th depending on weekends and banking holidays. On that date, Medium instructs Stripe to transfer your accumulated balance.

Funds land in your bank within 5–7 business days after Stripe initiates the transfer. US accounts are often faster — 2–3 business days is common. International transfers to banks in Southeast Asia, South Asia, or Africa typically take the full 5–7 days, with occasional delays beyond that.

The practical consequence: January earnings reach your bank in mid-to-late February at earliest. Medium is a slow-pay channel by design. Do not treat it as income you will see this month — build your cash flow plan around a 4–6 week lag from when you earn to when funds land.

What To Do If Stripe Rejects Your Bank

Bank rejections happen. Stripe Express does not accept all banks in all countries, and some banks actively reject incoming Stripe deposits even if Stripe accepts the account for setup. The rejection usually shows up as a failed transfer notification in your Stripe Express dashboard with a generic error code.

Work through these three fixes in order:

1. Try a different bank account in your name. Some banks have standing policies against Stripe payments — often for compliance reasons specific to their charter. If one bank rejects the deposit, another bank in the same country may accept it without any issue. This is the most common fix and requires no contact with anyone — just update the bank account in your Stripe Express dashboard and wait for the next payout cycle.

2. Use a Stripe-supported fintech wallet. Wise multi-currency accounts and Revolut both support Stripe Express deposits in most countries where they operate. Your country may have a local equivalent — check Stripe’s list of supported banks and financial institutions in the Express documentation. Set up the fintech account, add it in Stripe Express, and the next payout will route there instead. You can then transfer from the fintech wallet to your local bank on your own timeline.

3. Contact Stripe Express support directly. In your Stripe Express dashboard, there is a support link specific to Express accounts. Use that, not Medium’s general support. Medium support does not have access to your Stripe Express account and cannot resolve bank-side issues. Stripe Express support can review the specific rejection reason and tell you whether it is fixable or whether you need a different bank. Have your account details ready when you reach out.

In markets where Stripe Express support is limited, some countries have very few banks that work reliably with Stripe. Research your local options in writer communities or expat finance forums before you apply — finding this out during setup is far less frustrating than when your first payout fails to arrive.

Tracking Your Earnings

Medium provides an earnings dashboard, but it is not a substitute for your own records. The platform can change its reporting format; you need a log that works for tax purposes and that tells you what is actually driving your income.

A single Google Sheet or Notion page with these columns is enough:

| Month | Gross (USD) | Local-currency value | Stripe / bank fees | Net received | Notes |
|----------|-------------|----------------------|--------------------|--------------|--------------------------|
| Jan 2026 | \$41.20 | Rp 670,000 | \$1.80 | \$39.40 | “SwiftUI tips” drove 60% |

One row per month, updated when the transfer lands. The Notes column is the most underused part — one sentence on which story drove the month is information you will use for content decisions. If January's \$41 came almost entirely from a SwiftUI piece you wrote in September, that pattern is worth knowing.

The tax value of this log is straightforward: an independent record to cross-check against Medium's reported earnings and any 1099 or withholding documentation you receive. I have kept a version of this log since 2017. The most useful thing it shows is not the total — it is which content has a long tail and which content dies after a week. That pattern changes how you decide what to write next.

Chapter 10 takes everything set up across these nine chapters — the profile, the writing system, the publication relationships, the engagement habits, and the payout infrastructure — and puts it into a concrete 90-day calendar you can follow to turn this setup into ongoing, predictable income.

10 — The 90-Day Calendar

What This Chapter Covers

- A week-by-week schedule for the first 90 days, including what to write, what to submit, and what to measure at each stage
- Why publishing three topic tags consistently beats publishing on everything you know
- When to start your own Medium publication — and the specific thresholds that make it worth the time
- A three-question review you run at Day 90 to decide what comes next

The 90-Day Schedule At A Glance

The table below is your working calendar. Each week has a theme, a minimum output target, and a single goal. The goal is what you are testing or proving that week — not a hope, but a checkpoint.

| Week | Theme | Output | Goal |
|------|----------------|-------------------------------------|---|
| 1 | Foundation | 1 listicle in chosen niche | First publication submission |
| 2 | First feedback | 1 listicle + respond to comments | Read first metrics |
| 3 | Refine voice | 1 listicle (apply Week 1–2 lessons) | Build cadence rhythm |
| 4 | Month-1 review | 1 listicle + 30-day analysis | Lock niche, drop the worst-performing topic |
| 5 | Add format | 1 listicle + 1 essay or tutorial | Test second format |

| Week | Theme | Output | Goal |
|------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 6 | Pitch wider | 1 listicle + 1 alt-format | Submit to second publication |
| 7 | Engagement focus | 2 articles + reply campaign | Build follower momentum |
| 8 | Month-2 review | 2 articles + earnings check | Identify best-performing format |
| 9 | Double down | 2 articles in best format | Settle into proven cadence |
| 10 | Friend links | 2 articles + share campaign | Drive Friend Link conversions |
| 11 | Pre-100 push | 2 articles + final optimization | Approach \$100 milestone |
| 12 | Month-3 review + decision | 1 article + planning | Hit \$100 OR diagnose what's missing |

A few things to notice about the structure. Weeks 1–4 ask for one article per week. That is intentional — you are learning, not scaling. The second month asks for two per week once you know what is working. The output total for the full 90 days is twelve articles at minimum, which maps directly to the topic clustering strategy in the next section.

The “30-day analysis” at Week 4 is not optional. That review is when you make your first real decision: which of the topics you tried in the first month is worth continuing, and which one to drop. If you skip it, you go into Month 2 without data, which means you are still guessing about what resonates.

The earnings check at Week 8 is a reality check, not a celebration. At two months in, most writers have earned between \$5 and \$40. The number itself is less important than the pattern — which articles are still earning from a rolling 30-day window, which ones dropped off after the first week, and whether the format you added in Week 5 outperformed or underperformed your original listicles.

Topic Clustering: Pick 3 Tags

Before Week 1, choose exactly three topic tags you want to be known for. Write four articles in each tag across the 90 days. That gives you twelve articles total — one per week — distributed evenly across three topics.

This is not about personal preference alone. The tag selection has a direct effect on discoverability. Medium's recommendation engine surfaces your work to readers who previously read and engaged with articles in the same tag. If a reader finishes an article in the "SwiftUI" tag and your next "SwiftUI" article appears in their feed, that is the recommendation loop working. It compounds: the more you publish consistently in a tag, the more the engine has to work with, and the more readers it can match you to.

The compounding effect breaks down if you dilute your publishing across unrelated topics. An account that publishes one SwiftUI article, then one on personal finance, then one on travel, gives the recommendation engine nothing coherent to match. Each article starts cold with no existing audience in that tag to build on.

A worked example: a writer choosing "SwiftUI," "iOS Development," and "Mobile Development" would plan four articles in each tag across 12 weeks. The three tags are related but distinct — a reader who engages heavily with iOS Development content is likely to see your SwiftUI work in their feed too, because those readerships overlap. That overlap is the distribution you want.

The tags do not have to be that closely related, but they should represent a coherent identity. "Python," "Data Science," and "Machine Learning" work the same way. "iOS Development," "Productivity," and "Cooking" do not — the readerships do not overlap, and you get no compounding benefit across the three.

Write down your three tags before you publish your first article. Treat them as a constraint, not a limit.

When To Start Your Own Publication

Do not start your own Medium publication in the first 90 days. The exception is if you are bringing an existing audience with you — but if that were the case, you probably would not be reading this chapter.

For a writer starting fresh, creating a self-publication in the first 90 days costs more than it returns. Running a publication means handling submissions from other writers, editing, and maintaining editorial standards. More importantly, a new self-publication with no track record gets no algorithmic distribution boost. You do not get more reach by

publishing under your own brand name instead of an established publication's — you get less, because established publications have built readership that gives your work an immediate audience.

Start your own publication only when one of these thresholds is true:

- You have earned at least \$100 per month consistently for two consecutive months, which means you have proven the content works and you have something to invest the extra time into.
- You have at least 25 organic followers in your niche — people who followed you because of the content, not because you asked them to.

The threshold is not arbitrary. At \$100/month for two months, you have proof that the writing converts into income. You can afford to spend time on publication management because the channel is generating returns. At 25 niche followers, you have a small but real audience that will carry over to your publication's early posts rather than the publication launching into silence.

Before either of those thresholds, the higher-return move is to stay active in existing publications. The publications with 5,000 to 50,000 followers distribute your work to their established readers on day one. You get that for free by submitting well. Starting your own removes that distribution advantage and adds an editorial workload on top of your writing.

The 3-Question 90-Day Review

On Day 90 — or close to it — sit down with your Medium Partner Program dashboard and answer three questions. Write the answers down somewhere you will keep them. They feed directly into the decisions in Chapter 11 and Chapter 12.

1. Which article earned the most?

Go to the Partner Program dashboard, find the earnings breakdown by story, and sort by lifetime earnings. Whichever article is at the top is your current proof point. That is the format, length, niche, and framing that the Medium audience has responded to with reading time and money. It is not luck — it is signal. Write more articles in that format.

2. Which article got the most reads?

Read count is different from view count. Views include every person who clicked through, including people who left after five seconds. Reads count only people who stayed long enough to be considered a genuine read — Medium's threshold is approximately 30 seconds or reaching a certain percentage of the article. High read count on a piece that

earned less than expected tells you the audience is there but the format or length may not be optimal for MPP earnings. High earnings on a piece with moderate reads tells you the readers who do stay are highly engaged.

Sometimes the top earner and the top read-count article are the same piece. When they are different, that gap is worth understanding before you scale.

3. What surprised you?

This is the question most people skip, and it is often the most useful one. Surprise is data. The article you worked hardest on that barely moved. The short, casual piece you almost did not publish that outperformed everything. The comment thread that went in a direction you did not expect, or the niche you picked reluctantly because it felt too obvious and it turned out to have a hungry audience. Write down one unexpected hit and one unexpected miss.

The surprise question is not about explanation — you do not have to figure out why. You are collecting the data point. Over time, patterns emerge from the surprises. Many writers discover their best-performing content was something they nearly left out of their publishing plan.

These three answers are your inputs for Chapter 11, which walks through turning a proven article into a Gumroad product, and Chapter 12, which covers what decisions to make once you have hit or closely approached \$100.

Common 90-Day Mistakes

- Switching niches every two weeks kills the tag-based recommendation engine before it has a chance to build any compounding momentum for you.
 - Posting daily for the first month then burning out by Week 5 leaves a gap in your publishing history that resets whatever cadence rhythm the algorithm had started associating with your account.
 - Writing only one format — listicles exclusively — leaves you with no data on whether your voice works as well in essays or tutorials, which is exactly the data you need for the decisions in Month 3.
 - Ignoring the engagement loop — replying to comments, clapping for articles in your niche, following back relevant writers — means you are publishing in one direction only and missing the fastest way to build organic followers in the first 90 days.
 - Refusing to submit to existing publications because “I’ll start my own soon” delays your access to an established readership by months, for no concrete gain in the early stages.
-

Chapter 11 takes the best article from your 90-day run and walks through the exact steps to turn it into a Gumroad product — converting what is already proven to earn on Medium into a second income stream outside the platform. If your Day 90 review surfaced a clear winner, that is the starting point.

11 — Repurpose: Medium → Gumroad Funnel

What This Chapter Covers

- Why a single proven Medium article can become a Gumroad product that earns more per month than the article ever will on Medium alone
- The four signals that tell you an article is worth expanding — and why all four must be true, not just one
- The exact expansion pattern: how to scale a 12-item listicle into a 12,000-word PDF that buyers are willing to pay \$19 for
- How to connect Medium and Gumroad into a self-reinforcing loop so each platform feeds the other

The Principle: 1 Hit Listicle = 1 Paid PDF

Medium pays per read, measured in fractions of a cent. A 1,500-word article that earns \$67 over its lifetime is a genuine win — most articles never get there. But the same article, expanded into a thorough guide and priced at \$19 on Gumroad, only needs 10 buyers to generate \$190. And those 10 buyers can arrive over 12 or 24 months, as long as the product stays listed.

That is the asymmetry. Medium pays you once per read for the same content, repeatedly. Gumroad pays you per buyer, and buyers discover products through search and recommendations — channels that do not decay the way a Medium article's feed position does.

A real example from this book's own backstory: a SwiftUI listicle earned \$67.99 on Medium in its first few months. That content, expanded with more examples and a proper introduction, became the seed for a Gumroad product that continues to sell. The Medium article kept earning in the background, but the Gumroad product added a second revenue layer on top.

The repurpose move does not mean abandoning Medium. It means treating a strong article as proof that an audience exists, then building something more substantial that the same audience is willing to pay for directly.

Identifying A “Hit” Worth Expanding

Not every article deserves to become a product. The expansion move is only worth the time when four specific signals are all true at once.

Read count above 1,500 in the first 30 days. The baseline floor. 1,500 reads in 30 days means the topic found an audience quickly. An article at 400 reads may still be good, but it does not have enough demand evidence to justify a major expansion effort.

Reads-to-views ratio above 25%. Views count everyone who clicked. Reads count people who stayed long enough to actually read. A 25% ratio means one in four people who clicked stayed and finished. That says the content matched the headline’s promise. A 10% ratio means the headline pulled clicks but the content did not hold attention — that article does not expand well into a product.

At least five specific implementation comments. Claps are easy. Comments like “I tried this and it worked” or “I applied item 7 and here is what happened” are the real signal. Those comments confirm readers acted on the content. People who act on content buy products built from the same content. General praise does not carry this weight.

The niche has known buyers. Dev tools, productivity systems, finance tactics, career frameworks — these are categories where people already buy guides and templates. Personal stories and opinion pieces can earn well on Medium, but they do not convert to Gumroad sales at the same rate. Before expanding, check: does a Gumroad search in this topic return existing products with ratings? If yes, buyers exist.

When all four signals are present, the expansion is lower risk. When only two or three are present, you can still try — but go in knowing the odds are lower.

The Expand Pattern

The difference between a Medium article and a Gumroad product is not just length. It is depth, completeness, and the sense that the reader has everything in one place.

A typical strong Medium listicle: 12 items, 200 words each, 2,400 words total. Good for Medium. Not enough for a \$19 product.

The expanded version starts with those 12 items and adds 38 more — 50 total at 200 words each — making the list body 10,000 words. Then the full guide adds:

- A 1,000-word introduction on the WHY of the topic — why it matters now, who it is for, and what changes when applied consistently
- Worked examples for abstract items: what it looked like in practice, what went wrong, what the adjusted version produced

- A “how to use this guide” section explaining whether to read front to back or use it as a reference, and what to do on day one
- A glossary for technical terms
- A “next steps” section pointing to related products — a map, not a pitch

The finished product runs 12,000–15,000 words, which formats as 80–120 pages as a PDF. At that length, for \$19, buyers consistently report feeling they got their money’s worth.

Production does not require design software. Markdown compiled through Pandoc with a basic CSS stylesheet is enough for a first product. One cover image. The content does the work.

Pricing Rules Of Thumb

Charge based on what you deliver, not on what feels comfortable. Undercharging trains buyers to expect more than they paid for and makes the time economics difficult.

\$5 — short swipe file: under 1,500 words, no design polish, pure utility. A prompt list, checklist, or single template.

\$9 — short ebook: 3,000–5,000 words, basic formatting, one cover image. A focused guide that saves research time.

\$19 — full guide: 10,000–15,000 words, professional PDF, embedded screenshots, downloadable bonuses. The buyer expects something that replaces hours of scattered research.

\$29 — full guide plus serious bonuses: templates, checklists, source files, or a video walkthrough. The extras justify the \$10 step up.

\$49 — full guide plus a course module: five or more video lessons or a structured curriculum with exercises. Buyers are paying for guided learning, not just reference material.

The rule that matters most: a \$19 product that delivers \$190 of practical value gets word-of-mouth. A \$9 product that delivers \$9 of value is forgotten by the week after purchase.

Worked Example: The Author’s Catalog

Here is how the Medium-to-Gumroad path played out across five products in this author’s catalog — as case studies, not promotion.

1000 Expert Prompts (\$9). Started as a Medium article covering ten ChatGPT prompts used weekly. Reader demand for more categories led to an expansion covering 1,000 prompts across ten categories (Marketing, SEO, Business, Dev, AI, Writing, Social, Data, Design, Career). The article proved demand; the product delivered the full catalog.

Medium Income 2026 (\$19). This book started with the author's own MPP eligibility experience and the \$67.99 SwiftUI listicle case study — data points that kept surfacing in article comments. The book is the expanded form of what would otherwise have stayed scattered across several Medium posts.

Mastering Claude Code (\$19). Seeded by a “20 Claude Code tips” Medium article that drew specific implementation comments — readers describing workflows they built from the tips. The expansion to 20 full chapters with 50 hidden tips followed the article's signal that readers wanted depth.

Ollama API Monetizer (\$14). Started as a “How I Sold AI Inference” article — a walkthrough of setting up Ollama with a Lightning paywall. Comments asked for the exact scripts and config files. The product became a turn-key paywall guide with those files included as downloadables.

Nostr AI Toolkit (\$19). Started as a “Run an AI Bot on Nostr” walkthrough covering nak CLI and DVM fundamentals. The audience — developers wanting Nostr automation but finding the documentation scattered across too many repos — needed a consolidated resource. The product became a full DVM toolkit with working example code.

Across all five: an article surfaced a specific audience with a specific gap. The product filled that gap more completely than a single article could.

Gumroad Listing Essentials

A strong product with a weak listing does not sell. Buyers decide based entirely on what they see on the listing page. Five things make or break that decision.

Three mockup images. Cover plus two page previews. Buyers who can see actual interior content convert at a higher rate than buyers looking at a cover alone. A screenshot of one or two PDF pages, cropped cleanly, is enough.

Three-paragraph description. Hook (what is this and what does it change?) → what is inside (specific numbers: 50 items, 10 categories) → who it is for (specific enough that the right reader thinks “that is me,” not “anyone who wants to earn online”).

Three testimonials or proof shots. Beta reader feedback, earnings screenshots, or the author's own Medium dashboard showing earnings from the article that seeded the product. Something concrete.

Five-question FAQ. Address the five objections that turn browsers into non-buyers: “Is this for beginners?” “Does this require X?” “What if I already have Y?” “How long will implementation take?” “What is the refund policy?” Answering these before the buyer asks removes friction.

A clear refund policy. Fourteen days, no questions asked, is standard. It reduces purchase hesitation without meaningfully increasing actual refund rates.

The Cross-Promo Loop

Every Gumroad product description links back to your Medium profile. Buyers discover products through Gumroad search, then visit your profile, read two or three articles, and become followers — which makes them more likely to buy the next product too.

Every Gumroad confirmation flow includes an email list signup prompt. The people who buy your products are your best future buyers. Capturing their email at purchase builds a launch audience for the next product without starting from zero.

Every Medium article’s footer carries a Friend Link and a single CTA line: “Want the expanded version? See [product name] on Gumroad.” One sentence. Both together mean every time someone reads an old article, there is a path from that read to a sale.

Every new Gumroad product launch gets a Medium “behind the scenes” article — not a sales post, but a genuine piece about building the product. That article links naturally to the product, earns on its own merits, and drives launch-week traffic the Gumroad algorithm notices.

The loop compounds: Medium readers become Gumroad buyers. Gumroad revenue funds more Medium writing time. More articles create more starting points for future products. Each platform reinforces the other.

Chapter 12 covers what to do after the first \$100 — which milestones to track next, how to decide between scaling Medium output or adding new products, and what changes when the income ceiling becomes the real constraint.

12 — What Comes After the First \$100

What This Chapter Covers

- The five concrete paths you can take once your Medium earnings clear \$100 — and how to choose the one that fits where you actually are, not where you wish you were
- The four mistakes that reliably kill momentum for writers who reach the milestone but never move past it
- Why consistent publishing compounds the way a savings account does, and what the math looks like when you stay the course past month three
- Where to go from here: the bonus materials, the next steps, and the one habit that determines whether \$100 becomes \$1,000

The Decision Tree At The \$100 Milestone

Reaching \$100 on Medium is not luck. It means you picked a niche, published consistently enough to get accepted into the MPP, wrote at least a few articles that connected with readers, and waited. Most people who start a Medium account never get here. You did.

Now the question changes. Before \$100, the question was: *how do I get started?* After \$100, it becomes: *which direction do I push?*

There are five realistic paths. Each one suits a different type of writer and a different situation. Choose one — not all five.

Niche down further. Pull your stats and identify your two lowest-earning topics. Drop them. Take your highest-earning topic and commit to it fully. If you have been writing about iOS development, SwiftUI, and remote work, and iOS tutorials are earning three times what the others are, that is your signal. Cut the others, at least for the next 90 days. Writers who niche down after their first \$100 typically see earnings move from \$100 to \$300 per month within three months, because the algorithm clusters their content and their growing reader base becomes more targeted. This path suits writers who want to grow within Medium itself rather than branching out immediately.

Hire an editor. At \$30–50 per article via Upwork or Fiverr, a good editor will tighten your structure, catch logic gaps, and improve readability in ways that genuinely lift earnings. This path suits writers who are already shipping six or more articles per month, because the per-article cost only makes sense at that volume. The return is not dramatic — expect 20–30% higher earnings on edited articles compared to unedited ones at the same word count — but the consistency compounds. Your voice stays yours; the editor just removes friction for the reader.

Ghostwrite for others. Once you have published 20+ articles in a specific niche and your Medium profile shows real results, other professionals in that space will pay for your writing. Rates for ghostwritten articles in established niches run \$100–500 per article depending on length and the client’s audience size. This is not passive income — it is a service. But it is a service that builds on the exact credibility your Medium catalog already built. Writers with established niche authority who want to add \$500–2,000 per month on top of their Medium earnings should seriously consider this path before anything else.

Launch a paid newsletter. Medium is a great acquisition channel, but it is not an owned one. Converting your Medium followers to email subscribers on Substack or Beehiiv gives you a direct line that no algorithm change can cut. A paid newsletter at \$5 per month only needs 100 paying subscribers to generate \$500 per month. That scales linearly: 200 subscribers is \$1,000. The hard part is identifying what weekly or bi-weekly insight you can deliver reliably. If you already have a clear angle that runs through all your Medium articles, you likely already have the concept. The execution is just packaging it and asking your readers to subscribe.

Build a digital product. Chapter 11 covered this path in detail. The short version: if any of your Medium articles map clearly to a buyer pain — something people would pay to solve or learn — you already have evidence that a product will sell. A Gumroad listing at \$19 needs 10 buyers to generate \$190, and it keeps selling as long as it is listed. This path suits writers whose Medium hits are not just about curiosity topics but about practical problems readers need to solve.

The 4 Mistakes That Kill Momentum After \$100

Most writers who reach \$100 do not keep going. Not because writing is hard, but because success introduces a specific set of bad habits that slowly undo the focus that got them to \$100 in the first place.

Chasing every new niche. Your \$100 came from focus. You wrote about something specific, and readers who cared about that specific thing found you. Jumping to a new topic — because it feels fresh, because another writer is doing well with it, because you

are bored — splits your catalog and confuses both the algorithm and your readers. The writers who go from \$100 to \$500 are almost never the ones who diversified. They are the ones who went deeper.

Posting daily without quality control. Medium's earnings are driven by time-in-article and member reads. A well-structured 1,200-word piece that holds attention for five minutes earns more than seven 500-word pieces that readers skim in 45 seconds. Daily posting is not a reliable growth strategy on Medium. It is a reliable way to burn out, lower your average quality, and confuse your existing readers about what you actually stand for. One great article per week consistently beats seven mediocre ones, both for earnings and for building a reputation.

Ignoring the email list. Medium has changed its partner program rules multiple times since 2017. The reading time calculation changed. The payout structure changed. The curation system changed. If you build your entire writing business on a platform you do not own, you are one policy update away from starting over. An email list — even 200 subscribers — is yours regardless of what Medium does next. Every writer at \$100 should already be pointing readers somewhere they can follow you directly. If you are not, that is the highest-priority fix, before choosing any of the five paths above.

Letting your Medium membership lapse. This one is operational but worth stating clearly. If your paying Medium member status expires, your MPP eligibility ends immediately. You cannot earn from members-only reads on articles you have already published, and new articles you publish will not be eligible either, until membership is active again. The \$5 per month you pay is a direct prerequisite for the income you are building. Treat it as a business expense, not a subscription to manage alongside Netflix.

The Compounding Mindset

There is a mathematical reality about content publishing that most people understand in theory but do not feel until it happens to them.

When you publish your sixth article, your total catalog is six articles. When you publish your twenty-fifth, it is twenty-five. When you publish your fiftieth, it is fifty. None of those earlier articles disappear. They keep getting indexed in search, surfaced in recommendations, and read by new members who find them months after you wrote them. Article #50 does not replace articles #1 through #49. It adds to them. Each one is a small, persistent earning machine that runs in the background while you write the next one.

The earnings curve is not linear. It is closer to what happens in the early phase of compound interest: the first few months look flat, the numbers feel discouraging, and most writers quit right before the curve begins to angle upward. The 6-article catalog

earns less per article than the 50-article catalog, not because the writing got better (though it probably did), but because there are simply more articles compounding simultaneously.

The numbers from this book's backstory illustrate the point without exaggerating it. Fifty-plus stories published across several years. 1,171 followers accumulated without any paid promotion. Monthly earnings ranging from \$17 to \$92, depending on how many new articles shipped in a given month and which older articles resurfaced. Those are modest numbers. They are also durable. That catalog earns every month without requiring new promotion, new platforms, or new strategies. The consistency built something that holds.

The writers who make it past month three are not the most talented ones in the room. They are the ones who treated publishing as a habit rather than a campaign.

Where To Next

This guide gave you the structure. The next move is yours.

Use the bonuses. The 30 title templates, 8 article skeletons, 14-day publishing calendar, and Stripe payout checklist are in the [bonuses/](#) folder of this download. They are not decorative extras — they are the tools this guide references throughout. If you have not opened them yet, start there before you write your next article.

Leave a Gumroad rating. If this guide helped you ship your first article or clarify your next step, a short rating on Gumroad makes it easier for other beginners to find it. Gumroad products surface partly on reviews, the same way Medium's curation runs on engagement. A few sentences from you helps the next writer in your position.

Follow the author on Medium. New articles go up at @luffyselal on Medium, longer-form writing and updates at jrdevhub.com, and new products at gumroad.com/zerix1. If you want to see what a consistent catalog looks like in practice — the publishing rhythm, the topics, the results — those are the places to watch.

The first \$100 is the milestone. The next 100 is the habit.

Appendix A — 30 Title Templates

The full set of 30 battle-tested title templates lives in `bonuses/30-title-templates.md`. That file groups them by hook pattern — curiosity gaps, number lists, mistake frames, milestone confessions — with notes on which formats perform best in tech, personal finance, and career topics on Medium. If you only read one bonus file, make it that one. Below are five samples to get you started before you open the folder.

- `[N] [items] I Use [daily / every day / in production]`
 - `[N] [items] That [Saved Me / Changed My / Made Me $Y]`
 - `[N] [items] Most [audience] Get Wrong`
 - `[N] [items] I Wish I Knew Before [milestone]`
 - `After [X years], Here Are [N] [items] Worth Knowing`
-

Appendix B — 8 Article Skeletons

The complete set of eight skeletons is in `bonuses/8-article-skeletons.md`. Each skeleton covers a different article format — tech listicle, story arc, tutorial, income report, opinion piece, tool review, case study, and beginner guide. They are not rigid outlines; treat them as default structures you adjust to fit the topic. The skeletons are short on purpose: they show shape, not content. Below is the tech listicle skeleton so you have something to work from right now.

```
Hook (3-5 sentences: pain → promise → proof)
Why this list now (1 paragraph: why these items, why now)
Items 1-N (consistent format per item: name → 1-paragraph explanation → optional
code)
Bonus item (1 surprise that adds value beyond the count)
CTA + Friend Link footer
```

Appendix C — Pre-Publish Audit Checklist

Run through this before hitting Publish. Twelve items. Each one has caught a real mistake.

- Title under 70 characters
 - Title uses a number + hook pattern from Chapter 4
 - Hook in the first 3 sentences (no backstory before the pain)
 - One image per major section
 - All images have captions + photographer credit
 - Subheads in sentence case, every 200–300 words
 - Code blocks under 30 lines, with plain-English explanation before each
 - One pull-quote, 12–20 words
 - Exactly one CTA at the end (not three)
 - Friend Link footer included
 - 3 topic tags (not 5) chosen for niche focus
 - Mobile preview checked (Medium has a built-in preview)
-

Glossary

AI Policy — Medium’s rule that undisclosed AI text is demoted to “Network only” distribution and disclosed AI content cannot be paywalled.

Boost — Medium’s distribution program that nominates stories for extra reach (~7% earnings bump in 2026, down from ~30% in 2024).

Boost Nomination — when a Boost-eligible publication nominates a story for the Boost program.

Claps — engagement signal (1–50 per reader); influences distribution but not direct payout.

Conversion Bonus — extra payout when a non-member converts to a paying member during a session reading your paywalled story (added February 17, 2026).

Curation — Medium’s editorial process that surfaces stories in topic feeds.

Friend Link — a special URL paying members can share that lets non-members read paywalled stories for free; reads still count toward writer earnings.

Friend Tier — the \$15/month membership tier that pays writers approximately 4× more per minute of read time compared to the \$5 Member tier.

Highlights — passages readers save and share; an engagement signal that Medium factors into distribution.

Member Tier — the \$5/month base membership tier.

MPP — Medium Partner Program; the system that pays writers based on member reading time.

Publication — a curated collection of stories on Medium that distributes member content under its own editorial identity.

Read Ratio — reads divided by views; signals how many people who clicked actually finished the story.

Stripe Express — Stripe’s hosted onboarding flow that Medium uses to handle writer payouts globally.

W-8BEN — IRS form non-US writers complete to claim foreign tax status and, where tax treaties apply, reduce US withholding on earnings.

Next Steps

Use the bonuses. The guide is the map; the bonus files are the tools. Open `bonuses/30-title-templates.md` before you write your next headline. Use `bonuses/8-article-skeletons.md` to outline the draft. Follow the `bonuses/90-day-calendar.md` to pace yourself. Complete the Stripe checklist before you publish anything paywalled. And if you plan to funnel readers to Gumroad, the `bonuses/funnel-sop.md` walks you through the setup step by step.

Leave a Gumroad rating. If this guide saved you time or helped you earn your first dollar on Medium, rate it on Gumroad. A short honest review is how other beginners find the guide. It takes under two minutes and it matters more than you think.

Follow for updates. Medium's policies and payout mechanics shift every few months. When they do, this guide gets updated. Follow Jeri PM. on Medium at @luffyselalah to catch update announcements. The jrdevhub.com newsletter covers the same ground for people who prefer email. New products — including topic-specific writing guides and prompt packs — go up at gumroad.com/zerix1.

Now close this PDF and go pick a topic.